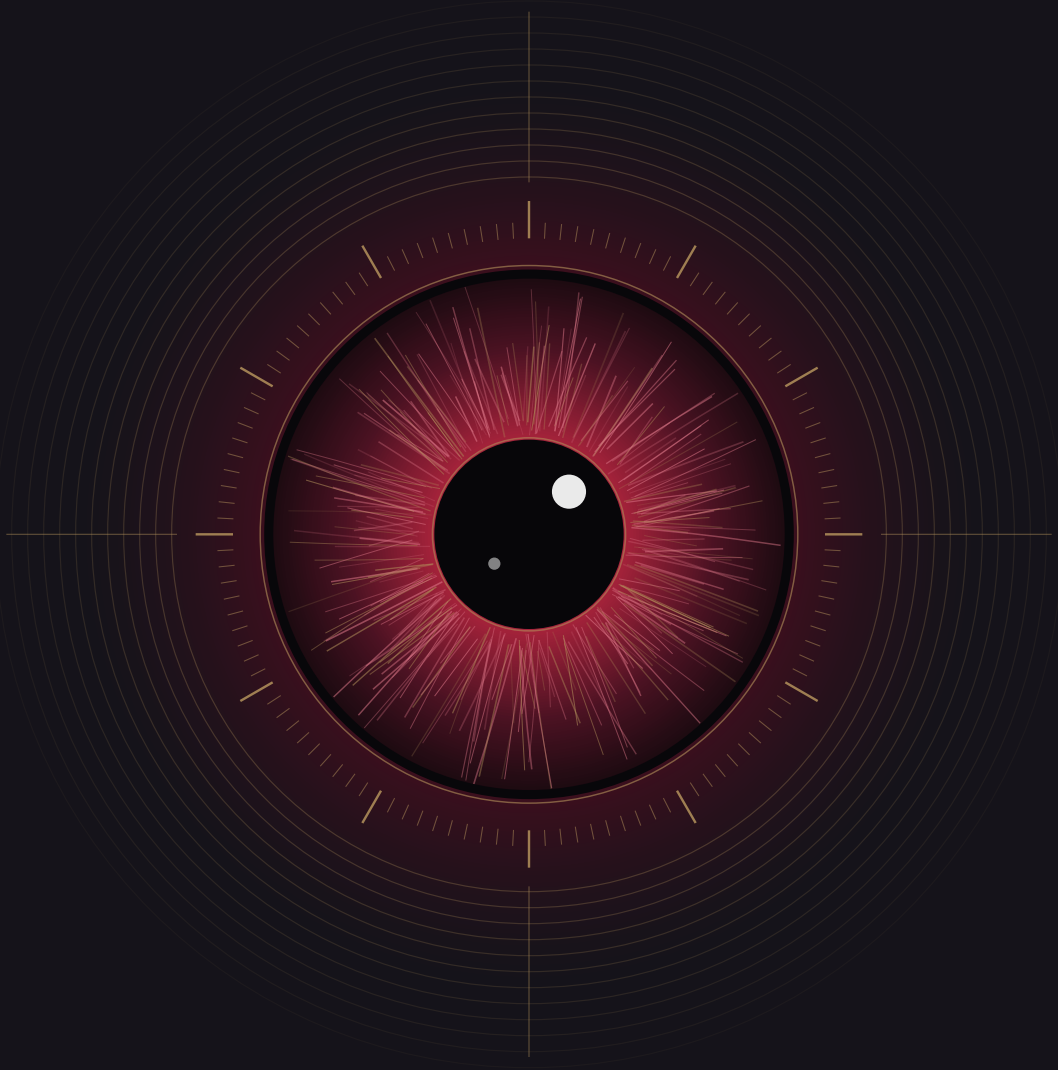


AIDOS EX MACHINA

Shame, Counterfeit, and the Mercurial Covenant in Philip K. Dick's Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?

A DISSERTATION

OCTOBER 2026

Contents

Abstract 4

Note on Texts, Editions, and Method of Citation 6

Introduction: From *Eidos* to *Aidōs* 7

PART ONE · GENEALOGIES OF THE BOUNDARY 13

1 The Exhaustion of the Eidetic Criteria 14

2 The Invention of Empathy 20

PART TWO · THE COUNTERFEIT SACRED 25

3 Mercer, the Death of God, and the Beetle in the Box 26

4 *Pecus*, *Pecunia*, Kipple: The Animal Standard and the Gresham Law of Being 31

5 Simulacrum, Aura, and the Returned Gaze 36

PART THREE · *AIDŌS EX MACHINA* 41

6 The Blush and the Polis: Protagoras, Darwin, and the Voigt-Kampff Apparatus 42

7 The Mercurial Covenant: Hermes, Media, and the Two Broadcasts 47

8 The Levitical Day: Scapegoat, Substitution, and the Inverse Hexaemeron 51

PART FOUR · COMPARATIVE HORIZONS 56

9 The Android Archive: Ancestors, Contemporaries, Descendants 57

PART FIVE · THE AIDETIC TURN 62

10 Pamina, *Puberty*, and the Scream: The Android as Spectator 63

11 Iran's Despair and the Counterfeit Bride: Affect, Gender, and the Household 66

12 The Electric Toad: Toward an Aidetic Ethics of the Counterfeit 69

Conclusion: *Aidōs* after the Human 73

Works Cited 75

Keywords 84

Abstract

THIS DISSERTATION ADVANCES a new interpretation of Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (composed 1966; published 1968). Against a half-century of criticism that has taken empathy to be the novel's criterion of the human—posited, operationalized, and then deconstructed—it argues that the novel's governing problem is the redistribution of *aidōs*: the reverential shame that, in the Protagorean myth (Plato, *Protagoras* 320c–322d), Zeus dispatches through Hermes to supplement Promethean *technē*, and without which, Zeus decrees, a being is to be put to death as a plague upon the city. Read beside Darwin's identification of blushing as "the most peculiar and the most human of all expressions" (1872), the Voigt-Kampff apparatus emerges as an instrument that measures not empathy but the somatic signature of shame, and the bounty hunter as the executor of the Protagorean law. The empathy box and its suffering deity, Wilbur Mercer—whose name descends from the Latin *merx*, the root antiquity also assigned to Mercurius, god of heralds, merchants, thieves, and the dead—constitute a technological re-institution of *aidōs* in a depopulated, post-civic world. Buster Friendly's televised exposure of Mercer as a studio counterfeit stages, in the year of *Time*'s "Is God Dead?", of Foucault's prophecy of the erasure of "man," and of Weizenbaum's ELIZA, the discovery that *aidōs* was always mediated, fiduciary, and counterfeit—and that it survives the discovery.

The study proceeds by what it terms an *aidetic reduction*: a deliberate inversion of Husserlian eidetic variation in which every essential criterion of the human—reason, language, memory, origin, passibility—is varied through the figure of the android until no invariant *eidos* remains and only a relational capacity, *aidōs*, is left standing. It reconstructs the novel's philosophical genealogy (Descartes, Hobbes, La Mettrie, Locke, Hume, Smith, Bentham, Kant, Schopenhauer, Scheler, Turing, Putnam, Wittgenstein, Arendt, Levinas, Derrida, Agamben, Stiegler, Baudrillard), its theological substrate (the Passion, Sisyphus, Gnostic cosmology, Levitical atonement, death-of-God theology), and its economic unconscious (the common root of *pecus* and *pecunia*; Gresham's law as the concealed form of the "law of kipple"; the novel's *animal standard* as an allegory of fiduciary value on the eve of the end of monetary convertibility). Comparative chapters situate the novel among its ancestors (Shelley, Hoffmann, Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, Wells, Čapek), its contemporaries (Asimov, Lem, Pynchon, Burgess, Kubrick and Clarke, Miller), and its descendants (Scott, Villeneuve, Garland, Ishiguro, Chiang, McEwan).

The dissertation culminates in the formulation of the *Mercurial Covenant*: a post-anthropological ethic in which the human is defined neither by an essence nor by the authenticity of what it reveres, but by the *vector* of its *aidōs*—its capacity to extend reverential care toward the counterfeit. To Bentham's sequence "Can they reason? nor, Can they talk? but, Can they suffer?", the novel appends a fourth and reflexive question, which this study identifies as its final philosophical bequest: *Can we blush before them?*

Note on Texts, Editions, and Method of Citation

THE NOVEL IS cited as *DADES*. The reference text is the Library of America edition (*Four Novels of the 1960s*, ed. Jonathan Lethem, 2007), collated against the Doubleday first edition (1968). The first edition sets the action in 1992; later printings advance the date to 2021. The present study treats that revision as symptomatic rather than incidental: the novel's future is perpetually re-dated forward, a futurity that never arrives and is therefore never falsified—a counterfeit date that continues to circulate at face value, in exactly the manner the fourth chapter attributes to the novel's economy of value.

Because pagination diverges widely across the Doubleday, Del Rey, Gollancz, and Library of America editions, episodes are identified by narrative position rather than by page. The novel's language is paraphrased rather than quoted, with the exception of its coined lexicon—*kipple*, *special*, *chickenhead*, *empathy box*, *Penfield mood organ*, *tomb world*, *Voigt-Kampff*, *retire*—which functions throughout as terminology. Dick's essays are cited from *The Shifting Realities of Philip K. Dick* (ed. Sutin, 1995) by title and year of composition.

Classical, scriptural, and rabbinic sources are cited by standard divisions: Stephanus pagination for Plato; line numbers for Hesiod, Homer, and the *Homeric Hymns*; chapter and verse for the Hebrew Bible and New Testament (in the Authorized Version where quoted); tractate, chapter, and mishnah for the Mishnah; folio for the Babylonian Talmud. Early modern and nineteenth-century philosophy is cited by part, chapter, or section so that any edition may be consulted. English quotations from pre-twentieth-century sources follow the public-domain translations listed in the Works Cited; twentieth-century philosophical and critical sources are paraphrased and cited author-date.

Three registers of evidence are distinguished and flagged wherever they shift. *Documented* claims concern sources Dick read, cited, or described. *Synchronic* claims concern works and events contemporaneous with the novel's composition, asserted as context rather than influence. *Constellational* claims assert structural homologies of the text, not intentions of its author; their method is set out in §I.3.

From *Eidos* to *Aidōs*

I.1 The Question and Its Displacement

THE TITLE OF Dick's novel is a question, and an unusual one. It asks not what androids are, nor whether they think, but what they dream—and the dream has been, since the *Traumdeutung* (Freud 1900), the privileged evidence of wish, and, since the First Meditation (Descartes 1641), the condition under which certainty about the world dissolves from within. Zhuangzi's butterfly (*Zhuangzi*, ch. 2) had long before made the dream the site at which identity cannot be adjudicated by the dreamer. Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940) completed the thought: a magician who dreams a man into existence discovers, when fire fails to burn him, that he too is being dreamt by another—the predicament of a hunter who cannot certify that he is not himself an android. The novel answers its titular question once, almost in passing: its protagonist, the bounty hunter Rick Deckard, reasons that androids evidently do dream, since they murder their owners on Mars and flee to Earth in search of a life without servitude. The android's dream is the slave's dream; its wish is freedom. Yet the novel does not stay with this answer. It converts the question of what androids want into the question of what humans are—and the critical tradition has, with notable unanimity, answered on the novel's behalf: empathy.

The consensus is broad and sophisticated. Hayles (1999, ch. 7) reads Dick's mid-sixties novels as "boundary work" in which the liberal-humanist subject is tested at its edges, and finds in *DADES* a criterion—empathy—that the narrative progressively destabilizes through Deckard's desire for Rachael Rosen and the affective vacancy of the human hunter Phil Resch. Galvan (1997) traces Deckard's initiation into a posthuman collective in which empathy at last extends across the line between organism and machine. Vint (2007) exposes empathy as the ideological alibi of a speciesist order in which animals and androids alike are commodities, reading the novel through Marx's concept of species-being. Jameson (2005) finds in Mercerism a degraded figure of utopian collectivity; Suvin (1975) a world of artifice in which refuge and prison are indistinguishable; Robinson (1984), Warrick (1987), Palmer (2003), and Rossi (2011) map the android onto the dark double, the schizoid self, and the postmodern dissolution of the real. Across their differences, these readings share a script. Empathy is posited as the human essence, operationalized by the Voigt-Kampff test, and then deconstructed by the narrative: by the coldness of a human who passes (Resch); by the apparent feeling of androids who fail (Roy Baty's anguish at his wife's death, Luba

Luft's absorption before Munch); by the mechanical manufacture of affect (the Penfield mood organ); and by the fraudulence of the religion that sanctifies empathy (Mercerism).

The script is correct as far as it goes, and it does not go far enough. It accepts the novel's own word, *empathy*, as the name of the thing in question and asks only whether the thing is present or absent, natural or simulable. It does not ask what the Voigt-Kampff apparatus actually measures; nor why its questions turn almost without exception on the hides, flesh, and bodies of animals converted into commodities; nor why the novel's two sacred objects—Mercer and the toad—are counterfeit and nonetheless efficacious; nor why the narrative ends not with a recognition of android personhood but with a woman ordering artificial flies for an electric toad while her husband sleeps. The deconstruction of empathy is not the novel's terminus. It is its threshold.

Dick's own account of the novel's genesis points past that threshold. In late interviews he located the origin of his androids in research for *The Man in the High Castle* (1962): reading the diary of an SS officer stationed in occupied Poland, he encountered the complaint that the cries of starving children kept the writer awake at night, and concluded that he was confronting a defective group mind for which the android became the figure (Sammon 1996). The anecdote is ordinarily cited as evidence that the android represents the absence of empathy. Its structure is more exact. The diarist does not fail to perceive the children's suffering; he perceives it precisely—as noise. Another's agony registers as an acoustic nuisance, an obstacle to sleep. What is missing is not perception but the inhibition that converts perception into obligation: the capacity to be undone by the cry, to be ashamed before it. The title's question returns transfigured. What does the android dream of once the cries are silenced? Electric sheep—the countable, interchangeable tokens by which insomnia is traditionally lulled. Counting is the diarist's anaesthetic. The title names the dream of a mind that has replaced hearing with enumeration, and Chapter 4 will show that the novel's entire economy is organized around the counting of animal heads.

Two precisions are owed to this anecdote, and the argument depends on both. First, Dick did not say which children the diary meant, but in occupied Poland hunger was policy. The German occupation administration set food rations for the Polish population far below subsistence, and those for Jews confined in ghettos such as Warsaw's lower still. The starvation the diarist heard was being carried out by the regime he served; he was complaining about the audible consequence of its measures. Second, the enumeration that the title's sheep figure was that regime's actual method. The SS administered deportation and murder through lists, transport tallies, and registers; at Auschwitz it tattooed registration numbers on prisoners' forearms; and in 1943 Himmler's statistician, Richard Korherr, reported the destruction of Europe's Jews to him as a statistical balance sheet (Chapter 8). The mind that replaces hearing with counting is not a metaphor drawn from that history. It is the administrative form that history took.

This dissertation argues that the category the novel seeks, and that *empathy*—a laboratory coinage of 1909—misnames, is older, more political, and more somatic: *aidōs*. In Homeric and classical Greek, *aidōs* names the inhibitory emotion of shame and reverence: before the gaze of others, before the gods, and above all before the vulnerable claims of the suppliant, the guest, the elder, and the dead (Cairns 1993; Williams 1993; Konstan 2006). Its kin *aidoia* names the parts of the body that must be covered. Hesiod made its departure the sign of the iron age's end: Aidōs and Nemesis, veiling their faces in white robes, abandon the broad earth for the company of the immortals, leaving to mortals bitter sorrows and no defence against evil (*Works and Days* 197–201). The world of *DADES*—irradiated, emptied by emigration, choked with kipple—is a world from which Aidōs has departed. Its religion is an attempt to summon her back through a cathode-ray tube.

I.2 Four Propositions

The argument is organized as four propositions, each demonstrated in the chapters indicated.

1. Displacement (Chapters 1, 2, 6). The Voigt-Kampff apparatus measures not empathy but the blush: capillary dilation and pupillary fluctuation in response to imagined complicity in harm. Since Darwin, the blush has been understood as the somatic index of self-attention to another's regard. The novel thereby displaces the question of the human from *eidos* (an essence: reason, language, memory, origin) to *aidōs* (a relation: the capacity to be undone before another's exposure).

2. Distribution (Chapters 6, 7). In the Protagorean myth, Zeus distributes *aidōs* and *dikē* through Hermes to all human beings, because Promethean *technē* alone cannot found a city, and decrees death for any being incapable of them. *DADES* depicts a post-Promethean world in which *technē* has been exteriorized into the android, the city has emptied, and *aidōs* must be redistributed by a technical medium—the empathy box—whose deity is, etymologically and functionally, Mercurial.

3. Counterfeit (Chapters 3, 4, 5). Buster Friendly's exposure of Mercer as a studio fabrication does not abolish *aidōs*; it reveals that *aidōs* was always mediated and fiduciary, like money after the end of convertibility. Its efficacy resides in practice, not in the authenticity of its object—a conclusion that Wittgenstein's beetle-in-the-box argument predicts and that Dick's own later criterion of reality confirms.

4. Covenant (Chapters 8–12). The novel's ending institutes a *Mercurial Covenant*: an ethic in which the human is defined neither by what it is nor by the reality of what it reveres, but by the vector of its *aidōs*. The human is the being that can blush before an electric toad. Bentham's sequence—reason, speech, suffering—is completed by a

fourth and reflexive question: *can we blush before them?*

I.3 Method: Constellation and the Aidetic Reduction

The comparative reach of this study—from the *Protagoras* to the Mishnah, from Darwin's physiology of the blush to the gold standard—requires a methodological warrant. It is taken from the epistemo-critical prologue to Benjamin's *Trauerspiel* book (1928), in which ideas stand to phenomena as constellations stand to stars: the idea is not abstracted from the phenomena but becomes legible in an arrangement of their extremes. A constellational claim is not a claim of influence. When this study observes that the Mishnah's scapegoat is pushed backward from a precipice and that Rachael Rosen pushes Deckard's goat from a roof, it does not assert that Dick consulted tractate *Yoma*; it asserts that the novel's structure becomes intelligible when the two are set side by side, as the structure of a symptom becomes intelligible in Althusser's *lecture symptomale* (1965) or in Jameson's political unconscious (1981). The three registers named in the prefatory note—documented, synchronic, constellational—are kept distinct so that the bolder correspondences never borrow the authority of the archive.

The study's organizing procedure is what it calls the *aidetic reduction*. The name inverts Husserl's eidetic reduction, in which an object is subjected to free imaginative variation until the invariant without which it would cease to be what it is—its *eidos*—stands out (Husserl 1913; 1939, §87). Science fiction is, in this sense, institutionalized eidetic variation: Suvin's "cognitive estrangement" (1979) names the variation of the empirical world under a hypothesis—the *novum*—in order to disclose its structure. The android is the human under imaginative variation, and *DADES* varies it exhaustively. The Nexus-6 reasons, speaks, remembers, appreciates art, fears death, grieves, and is born of no woman. No eidetic invariant survives. What remains when every property has been varied away is not a property but a relation: the capacity to blush before another. The aidetic reduction therefore brackets the question "what is the human?" in order to pose the question "before whom is the human ashamed?", and answers it not with a kind but with a vector. It is also, this study contends, the procedure of the novel's plot. Deckard's single day strips him of every eidetic certainty—an android police chief's claim that he is himself an android, the test he administers to a fellow hunter, the anomalous responses he registers in himself—until what remains is his shame before Mercer, before the androids, and before an electric toad.

I.4 The Triple Obituary of 1966

DADES was written in 1966, a year in which the three great referents of humanist modernity—God, Man, and the inner life of Mind—were each pronounced dead or shown to be reproducible. The synchronies tabulated below are contextual, not causal; of them, only the friendship with Bishop Pike is documented in Dick's biography (Sutin 1989).

Date (1966)	Event	Bearing on *DADES*
January	Weizenbaum publishes ELIZA, a program that simulates the reflective empathy of a Rogerian therapist	The first machine to perform empathy; its users attribute understanding to it
April	*Time* asks "Is God Dead?" on its cover, popularizing the death-of-God theologians	Buster Friendly's exposure of Mercer as a mass-mediated death of God
April	Foucault's *Les Mots et les choses* closes on the image of "man" erased like a face drawn in sand at the sea's edge	The indistinguishability of hunter and hunted
April	Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* imagines the Nefastis machine: a box bearing Maxwell's photograph, through which a "sensitive" communes with an anti-entropic demon	The empathy box: a screen bearing Mercer's image, through which users commune with an anti-entropic redeemer
1966	Altizer's *The Gospel of Christian Atheism*; Altizer and Hamilton's *Radical Theology and the Death of God*	Mercer as kenotic god, emptied into a bit-player and a soundstage
1966	Berger and Luckmann's *The Social Construction of Reality*	The empathy box as a plausibility structure built in hardware
1966	Jonas's *The Phenomenon of Life* grounds the difference between organism and mechanism in metabolism	Real animal versus electric animal
1966	Lorenz's *On Aggression* appears in English, arguing that technological killing at a distance outruns innate inhibition	The laser tube, World War Terminus, the uninhibited android
1966	Adorno's *Negative Dialektik* makes the voicing of suffering a condition of truth	Luba Luft before Munch; Iran's scheduled despair
October	Derrida delivers "Structure, Sign, and Play" at Johns Hopkins; the Episcopal House of Bishops censures Dick's friend Bishop James A. Pike for doctrinal heterodoxy	The decentred structure; a faith that survives the exposure of its doctrine

Read against this table, the novel appears as the literary condensation of a conjuncture. Buster Friendly's exposé is the death of God, broadcast. The vertigo of a hunter who cannot certify his own humanity is the erasure of man, administered. The empathy box and the mood organ are the technical simulation of interlocution and affect that ELIZA

inaugurated, domesticated. What distinguishes *DADES* from the obituaries is its refusal of their finality. Mercer returns after his exposure; the human returns, not as an essence but as a direction of care; and the simulated is not unmasked and discarded but tended. The novel is the year's counter-obituary.

I.5 Plan of the Work

Part One (Chapters 1–2) reconstructs the genealogy of the boundary. Chapter 1 demonstrates the exhaustion of every eidetic criterion of the human that philosophy has offered, from Descartes's two tests to Turing's imitation game. Chapter 2 traces the invention of empathy from Humean sympathy to Titchener's laboratory and Scheler's typology, and shows that the concept cannot bear the weight the novel's institutions place upon it. Part Two (Chapters 3–5) analyzes the counterfeit sacred: Mercerism and its exposure as a staging of demythologization and the death of God (Chapter 3); the economy of animal value as a monetary system governed by a Gresham law of being (Chapter 4); and the simulacrum, the aura, and the animal gaze (Chapter 5). Part Three (Chapters 6–8) develops the central thesis: the Voigt-Kampff test as a detector of *aidōs* executing the Protagorean law (Chapter 6); Mercer as Hermes and the empathy box as the medium of a Mercurial Covenant (Chapter 7); and Deckard's single day as a Levitical rite of substitution and expulsion inscribed in a biopolitical order (Chapter 8). Part Four (Chapter 9) situates the novel in the archive of the artificial human and proposes a typology of three regimes: Promethean, Cybernetic, and Aidetic. Part Five (Chapters 10–12) follows the aidetic turn through the novel's scenes of art (Chapter 10), of marriage and affective technology (Chapter 11), and of its final counterfeit (Chapter 12), where the ethic of the Mercurial Covenant is formalized in four theorems and defended against five objections. The Conclusion considers the covenant's demands in an age of synthetic interlocutors.



PART ONE

Genealogies of the Boundary

1 *The Exhaustion of the Eidetic Criteria*

2 *The Invention of Empathy*

I

The Exhaustion of the Eidetic Criteria

EVERY CRITERION BY which philosophy has proposed to distinguish the human from the artificial—language, universal reason, conversational indistinguishability, memory, organic constitution, origin, and passibility—is either satisfied by the Nexus-6 or failed by the humans of *DADES*. This chapter demonstrates that exhaustion criterion by criterion; Table 1 summarizes it.

1.1 Descartes's Two Tests and the Literalized *Bête-Machine*

The modern history of the problem begins with the fifth part of the *Discourse on Method* (1637), in which Descartes makes two claims of unequal fortune. The first is that a machine possessing the organs and outward figure of a monkey, or of any other irrational animal, could not be distinguished from the animal itself, since animals are themselves automata. The second is that a machine resembling our bodies and imitating our actions would always betray itself by two infallible marks: it could never arrange words so as to reply to the sense of whatever is said in its presence, as even the dullest of humans can; and, though it might excel at particular tasks, it would fail at others, revealing that it acts from the disposition of its organs and not from knowledge—for reason, in the Haldane–Ross rendering, is "a universal instrument which can serve for all contingencies."

DADES ratifies the first claim and refutes the second. Its electric animals are Descartes's hypothetical monkey fulfilled: the electric sheep on Deckard's roof cannot be told from a living one without opening the panel concealed in its fleece, and one of the novel's most poignant early episodes turns on John Isidore's inability to distinguish a dying cat from a malfunctioning replica. Its androids, conversely, pass both Cartesian tests with ease. The Nexus-6 converses, improvises, lies, and performs: Max Polokov impersonates a Soviet police officer convincingly enough to win a bounty hunter's confidence; Garland administers an entire counterfeit police precinct; Luba Luft sings Mozart at a professional standard. The Rosen Association has manufactured Cartesian human beings. The irony is structural. The culture of *DADES* reveres the living animal precisely as the negation of

mechanism, yet the difference it holds sacred is one that Descartes himself declared imperceptible. The value of the real animal lies in a metaphysical surplus—a non-mechanism that no perception can certify—and the novel's theology of the animal is, from its first page, a theology of the invisible difference.

The materialist tradition that answered Descartes is equally exhausted. Hobbes opened *Leviathan* (1651) by asking why all automata, engines that move themselves by springs and wheels, might not be said to have "an artificial life"; La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) extended mechanism to the human being and speculated that an ape, taught signs by the methods then used to instruct the deaf, might be educated into something hardly distinguishable from a little gentleman. The Nexus-6 is La Mettrie's ape industrialized—a being made human by design rather than tutelage—and it collapses the Cartesian dualism in La Mettrie's favour. Dick's androids are not mechanisms but organisms, biologically manufactured, identifiable with certainty only by post-mortem analysis of their bone marrow. The difference between human and android is therefore neither the difference between mind and extension nor that between organism and mechanism. It is a difference of genealogy—born or made—and genealogy, as §1.4 shows, fails in its turn.

1.2 Turing, Putnam, and the Affective Turn of the Test

Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) replaced the question whether machines can think with the imitation game, a test of conversational indistinguishability conducted by teleprinter. The Nexus-6 has passed it; that is the premise of the bounty hunter's profession. The Voigt-Kampff test is what remains once the imitation game has been lost. It retains the interview form but abandons its semantic channel, treating the subject's words as a pretext for measuring what words cannot control: capillary and pupillary response. The test is therefore less an affective Turing test than an anti-Turing test. Turing bracketed inner states in favour of behavioural performance; Voigt-Kampff brackets performance, which can be counterfeited, in favour of reflex, which supposedly cannot. Turing had anticipated the move. Among the objections he catalogued was the argument from consciousness, drawn from Geoffrey Jefferson's Lister Oration, which held that no machine could equal a brain until it wrote a sonnet from felt emotion; and the argument from various disabilities, which listed what machines would never do—be kind, be friendly, have a sense of humour, fall in love, enjoy strawberries and cream. *DADES* institutionalizes the objection Turing dismissed. Its androids may write the sonnet; the test asks whether they can be kind.

Fourteen years after Turing, and two before Dick wrote, Putnam's "Robots: Machines or Artificially Created Life?" (1964) argued that whether a sufficiently sophisticated robot is conscious is not a question awaiting discovery but one calling for a decision about how to extend our psychological vocabulary. The thesis is decisive for the reading advanced here,

because the novel ends on precisely such a decision: Deckard's resolution to treat an electric toad as the bearer of a life, however slight. Between Turing and Putnam on one side and the present on the other lie the later formulations of the problem—Nagel's irreducibly subjective character of experience (1974), Searle's syntax without semantics (1980), Chalmers's zombies (1996)—and the Nexus-6 has frequently been read as an *affective zombie*, cognitively complete and affectively lacunary. The novel withholds even that consolation. Roy Baty cries out in anguish when Irmgard is killed; Luba Luft stands transfixed before a painting of adolescent shame; Rachael Rosen's last act, whether grief or jealousy, destroys the one thing Deckard loves. The android is not demonstrably empty. It is undecidable, and the novel's institutions kill it because they cannot tolerate undecidability.

1.3 Memory, the Counterfeit Precinct, and Necropsic Epistemology

Locke's chapter on identity, added to the second edition of the *Essay* (1694, II.xxvii), located personal identity in consciousness extended backward to past actions—that is, in memory. The androids of *DADES* possess synthetic memory systems; some, the novel suggests, believe themselves human, and the Rosen Association equips Rachael with a fabricated biography—an upbringing aboard a spacecraft, isolated from human contact—designed to explain away her failure of the test. Mnemic continuity is therefore manufacturable, and its manufacture recoils on the human. Deckard and Resch cannot exclude, from within, that their own memories are implants; Resch's dread of being an android without knowing it is among the novel's most acute portraits of ontological insecurity. Dick's acknowledged early debt to A. E. van Vogt, whose Gilbert Gosseyn discovers in *The World of Null-A* (1948) that his memories of a dead wife are implanted and that he is one body in a series, passes through van Vogt to Korzybski's general semantics (*Science and Sanity*, 1933) and its principle that the map is not the territory. *DADES* is the point at which that genealogy turns the map against its maker.

The episode at the Mission Street Hall of Justice generalizes the doubt from memory to institutions. Detained while testing Luba Luft, Deckard is taken to a fully equipped police headquarters whose officers profess never to have heard of his department and whose chief, Garland, is an android. The precinct is a complete parallel apparatus of the state—a second variety of law—operating in a city unaware of its existence. Descartes's malicious demon (Meditation I) is here socialized: not my perceptions but my institutions may be counterfeit. The counterfeit precinct even possesses its own instrument, the Boneli reflex-arc test, which measures neural latency rather than the blush. Two states, two instruments, two definitions of the human: the episode exposes the test as a jurisdictional artefact. Beneath both lies the one certainty the novel admits, post-mortem marrow analysis. Knowledge of the human–android boundary is available only to the coroner. The

Voigt-Kampff therefore licenses the killing that alone could verify its verdict; its truth is *necropsic*, attained after the execution it authorizes. This is the epistemological scandal at the heart of bounty hunting, and the reason the novel can never allow the test simply to succeed.

1.4 Origin and Natality

The oldest criterion of the artificial is its origin. Shelley's creature (1818), Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's Hadaly (1886), and Čapek's robots (1920) are all made, not born, and the ethical drama of each turns on the fact of fabrication. *DADES* preserves the distinction—androids are manufactured and cannot reproduce—and then exhausts it from the human side. Arendt named the capacity to begin anew, rooted in the fact of birth, *natality*, and made it the ontological ground of political action (*The Human Condition*, 1958). In *DADES* natality is failing. Radioactive dust degrades the germ plasm; those whom it damages are classified as *specials*, barred from emigration, and sterilized; regulars submit to monthly examination; men wear lead codpieces to shield their gonads; the Deckards are childless. The android is the being that cannot begin, and the human is becoming one. The criterion of origin fails not because androids acquire natality—that miracle is reserved for *Blade Runner 2049*—but because humans are losing it. On the axis of origin, human and android converge on sterility.

1.5 From "Can They Suffer?" to "Can They Suffer-With?"

The decisive displacement in the modern history of moral standing is Bentham's footnote to the seventeenth chapter of the *Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation* (1789): "The question is not, Can they reason? nor, Can they talk? but, Can they suffer?" The question moves the criterion from cognition to passibility, and by that criterion the androids qualify without difficulty: they fear retirement, flee, plead, and grieve. The Voigt-Kampff inherits the Benthamite turn from cognition to affect but transforms it. It asks not whether the subject can suffer but whether the subject is moved by the suffering of another—not passibility but *compassibility*, a second-order and reflexive criterion. The androids are passible but, by stipulation, not compassible; Bentham's question would include them, while Voigt-Kampff's excludes them. The novel's criterion is therefore not utilitarian. It belongs to an older genealogy, which Chapter 2 reconstructs and Part Three names.

1.6 Androidization: Dick's Theory and Arendt's Functionary

Dick theorized his androids directly. In "The Android and the Human" (1972) he redefined the android as a behavioural and political category: the human being reduced to an instrument, rendered predictable, obedient, and incapable of the unexpected by the institutions that use it—a process he called androidization, which can befall persons of flesh while machines, conversely, may come to behave more humanly than their makers. "Man, Android, and Machine" (1976) sharpened the definition: the android is whatever is generated to deceive us cruelly into taking it for one of ourselves. These formulations confirm that for Dick the android was never a substrate but a stance, and they return the novel to its origin in the SS diary. Arendt's report on the trial of Adolf Eichmann (1963)—the SS officer who organized the deportation of Europe's Jews to ghettos and killing centres—diagnosed in him an inability to think from the standpoint of anyone else—a failure of the enlarged mentality that Kant made the condition of judgment (*Critique of Judgment* §40; Arendt 1982). Dick's android is the Eichmann-type rendered as a species.

But the novel's structure turns the diagnosis back upon its hunter. Deckard is himself the functionary of an extermination bureaucracy: he is paid per unit, he kills by euphemism (*retire*), and his colleague Resch, who enjoys the work, is certified human by the very instrument that condemns his victims. Arendt's functionary turns out to be the one who passes. Table 1 summarizes the chapter: every eidetic criterion either fails to exclude the android or fails to include the human.

Table 1. *The eidetic criteria and their exhaustion*

Criterion	Canonical source	Verdict on the Nexus-6	Verdict on the human
Language and universal reason	Descartes, *Discourse* V (1637)	Passed: converses, improvises, deceives, administers institutions	Isidore, classed a *chickenhead* by the state's intelligence test, fails a criterion the android passes
Conversational indistinguishability	Turing (1950)	Passed: hence the test abandons dialogue for physiology	No human can certify their own status from within (Deckard, Resch)
Memory and continuity	Locke, *Essay* II.xxvii (1694)	Satisfied by implanted memory systems and fabricated biographies	Any human memory may be an implant; the doubt is irreducible
Organic constitution	La Mettrie (1747); Jonas (1966)	Satisfied: organisms identifiable only by post-mortem marrow analysis	Shared: the difference is genealogical, not material
Origin and natality	Shelley (1818); Arendt (1958)	Failed: manufactured and sterile	Failing: radiation, sterilized *specials*, lead codpieces, childless households

Criterion	Canonical source	Verdict on the Nexus-6	Verdict on the human
Passibility	Bentham (1789)	Satisfied: fear, flight, grief	Satisfied
Compassibility	Voigt-Kampff; Mercerism	Failed by design	Resch passes while lacking it toward androids; schizoid humans fail while human

2

The Invention of Empathy

THE WORD THE novel uses for its criterion of the human was less than sixty years old when Dick wrote, and the concepts it gathers—Humean sympathy, Smithian projection, Schopenhauerian compassion, Lippsian *Einfühlung*, Schelerian fusion—are not one capacity but several, some of them mutually exclusive. This chapter separates them and shows that the novel's two empathy technologies instantiate incompatible strata of the concept.

2.1 Sympathy as Mirror and as Projection: Hume and Smith

Eighteenth-century sentimentalism bequeathed two models of fellow-feeling. Hume's *Treatise* (1739–40) describes sympathy as a quasi-mechanical communication of passions: the idea of another's affect, enlivened by its relation to the self, is converted into an impression and felt (T 2.1.11), so that "the minds of men are mirrors to one another" (T 2.2.5). Smith's *Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759) substitutes imaginative projection for contagion: since we have no immediate experience of what others feel, we place ourselves in their situation by fancy and "become in some measure the same person with him" (TMS I.i.1). Smith's model further generates the impartial spectator, the internalized witness before whom conduct is judged—an anticipation of the internalized other that Williams (1993) will locate at the core of Greek shame.

DADES splits the two models between its two empathic technologies. Mercerist fusion radicalizes Humean contagion: affect, and even injury, passes bodily from the figure to his users and among them. The Voigt-Kampff exploits Smithian projection: its questions are miniature hypotheticals—imagine you are given a calfskin wallet; imagine a scene in which a dog is cooked for dinner—that require the subject to enter a situation in fancy and register the result in the face. The novel thus distributes the sentimentalist inheritance across two machines, one for contagion and one for projection.

Hume's figure acquired a neural substrate three decades after the novel. Neurons in the macaque premotor cortex that fire both when the animal performs an action and when it

watches another perform it (Rizzolatti et al. 1996) were proposed as the mechanism of a simulation-based understanding of other minds (Gallese and Goldman 1998). The mirror model is a model of contagion: it explains how another's state comes to be reproduced in me. That is exactly why it cannot supply what the Voigt-Kampff seeks. A mirror reproduces; it does not blush. The difference between reproducing another's state and being ashamed before another is the difference this study names *aidōs*.

2.2 Compassion and the Animal: Kant and Schopenhauer

The animal enters this genealogy through the dispute between Kant and Schopenhauer. Kant held that cruelty to animals violates no duty owed to them but a duty of the human being to himself, since such cruelty dulls the shared feeling of suffering and so weakens a natural disposition serviceable to morality toward other persons (*Metaphysics of Morals*, Doctrine of Virtue §17). In the Collins lecture notes (1784–85) he illustrates the point with Hogarth's *Four Stages of Cruelty* (1751), in which a boy who tortures a dog becomes a coachman who beats a horse, then a murderer, and finally a corpse on the anatomist's table. Schopenhauer's prize essay *On the Basis of Morality* (1840) answered that compassion (*Mitleid*) is the sole genuine moral incentive, that it embraces every being capable of suffering, and that Kant's reduction of duties toward animals to indirect duties toward humanity was a scandal of European ethics.

Mercerism is structurally Kantian and affectively Schopenhauerian. Its mandate that every household keep and tend an animal functions as an indirect duty, a discipline by which human sociality is cultivated; its liturgy of shared suffering is pure *Mitleid*. The Hogarthian sequence returns in the novel with uncanny fidelity. Pris Stratton's dismemberment of a spider stands at the head of a progress whose last stage is the bone-marrow necropsy—the anatomist's table on which the android's identity is finally certified.

2.3 The Laboratory Birth of "Empathy"

The word itself is a laboratory product. Robert Vischer introduced *Einfühlung* in 1873 to name the projective animation of perceived forms; Theodor Lipps generalized it into a theory of inner imitation by which we apprehend artworks and other minds alike; and in 1909 Edward Bradford Titchener, lecturing on the experimental psychology of the thought-processes, rendered *Einfühlung* into English by way of the Greek *empatheia*. Empathy was born among instruments of introspection and reaction-time measurement, and the Voigt-Kampff merely returns it to its birthplace. From its origin the concept has been an instrument-concept, defined by what can be elicited and recorded.

Against the projective model, Edith Stein's dissertation *On the Problem of Empathy* (1917), written under Husserl, insisted that empathy is a sui generis act in which another's experience is given non-primordially—present to me as theirs, never as mine. The distance between the one who empathizes and the one empathized with is, for Stein, not a defect to be overcome but the very structure of the act. This insistence will prove decisive for the novel's ending.

2.4 Scheler's Typology and the Problem of Fusion

Max Scheler's *The Nature of Sympathy* (1913; revised 1923) provides the analytic instrument this study requires. Scheler distinguishes four phenomena routinely confused under the name of sympathy: the immediate community of feeling, in which two persons feel one sorrow together; fellow-feeling (*Mitgefühl*), in which I feel *with* another's sorrow as theirs; emotional contagion (*Gefühlsansteckung*), the involuntary transfer of affective states; and emotional identification (*Einsfühlung*), the limiting case of contagion in which one's own self is supplanted by another's. Scheler's examples of identification are telling: totemic participation, the ecstatic union of the ancient mysteries, hypnosis, the crowd, the bond of mother and infant, the moment of sexual union. Genuine fellow-feeling, he argues, presupposes the separateness of persons; identification is not its consummation but a pre-personal regression from it.

Mercerist fusion is *Einsfühlung* realized by apparatus. Gripping the handles of the empathy box, the user ceases to be distinct: they become Mercer, they become every other user at once, and the stones that strike Mercer draw blood from their own skin. By Scheler's analysis, the central rite of the novel's religion is therefore not ethical fellow-feeling but pre-personal identification. This explains a fact that the empathy-centred readings struggle to accommodate: fusion coexists with the bounty hunt without strain. One may fuse with Mercer in the morning and retire androids in the afternoon, because fusion requires no recognition of a separate other—it abolishes separateness. The Voigt-Kampff, by contrast, tests something nearer to *Mitgefühl*: a reaction to the imagined suffering of a distinct being. The novel's two empathy technologies thus correspond to two Schelerian strata, and its trajectory, traced in Chapter 12, moves from the first to the second—from fusion in a box to care at a distance.

2.5 Pathologies of Affect: Schizophrenia, Psychopathy, Inhibition

The concept of the android was assembled from the psychiatric literature of its moment, and the novel knows it. Bleuler, who coined *schizophrenia* (1911), made disturbance and flattening of affect among its cardinal signs. In *DADES*, a group of psychiatrists in Leningrad has raised the objection that a small class of humans with flattened affect might

fail the Voigt-Kampff and be retired; the novel thus writes the test's false positives, and the spectre of killing the mentally ill, into its premise—an echo, for a reader of Dick's Nazi archive, of the T4 programme (1939–41), in which the Nazi regime, acting through the Chancellery of the Führer and the physicians it enlisted, murdered more than 70,000 psychiatric patients and disabled people, most of them in gas chambers at six killing centres in Germany and Austria. Dick's writing on schizophrenia ("Schizophrenia & The Book of Changes," 1965) and his fiction of the same years (*Martian Time-Slip*, 1964) make the schizoid the hidden twin of the android. Laing's *The Divided Self* (1960) supplies the phenomenology: the ontologically insecure person fears petrification, being turned into a thing, and defends against it by turning others to stone. The android is the petrified self, and the bounty hunter is the one who must petrify it.

Cleckley's *The Mask of Sanity* (1941) described the psychopath as fluent, intelligent, and charming yet affectively void—a mind that knows the words of feeling but not the music, a condition Cleckley called semantic dementia. The Nexus-6 is Cleckley's psychopath industrialized. Later psychophysiology vindicated the Voigt-Kampff's premise with uncanny precision. Patrick, Bradley, and Lang (1993) found that psychopaths lack the potentiation of the startle reflex normally produced by aversive images; Blair (1995) proposed a violence inhibition mechanism, triggered by distress cues such as sad faces and tears, whose deficiency characterizes psychopathy. Blair derived his model explicitly from Lorenz's ethology of appeasement. In *On Aggression* (1963; English 1966), Lorenz argued that species armed with lethal natural weapons evolved inhibitions against killing conspecifics, triggered by gestures of submission, whereas the human being, whose weapons are technological, kills at distances from which the victim's appeal can no longer reach the killer's inhibition.

The Voigt-Kampff is a Lorenzian device: it measures the inhibitory reflex. World War Terminus, the apotheosis of killing at a distance, and the laser tube of the bounty hunter are Lorenz's nightmare made historical. The android is the being in whom the inhibition was never installed—and the hunter is the human whose inhibition his weapon is designed to circumvent.

The genealogy carries a fact that a reading built upon it must state. Lorenz joined the Nazi party in 1938. In a 1940 paper on behavioural disturbances caused by domestication, he argued that civilization degrades the human species as domestication degrades animals, and called for the *Ausmerzung*—elimination—of the "ethically inferior," in the vocabulary of Nazi racial hygiene. In 1942, serving as a military psychologist in German-annexed Poznań, he took part in a racial-psychological study of people of mixed German and Polish descent, intended to assess their suitability for "Germanization" (Deichmann 1996; Föger and Taschwer 2001). He later said he regretted having written in the regime's terms. The science of inhibition from which Blair's model descends thus passed through a scientist

who proposed to remove from the community those he judged deficient in moral endowment. That is the Voigt-Kampff's own logic—classification of persons by a moral faculty, followed by their elimination—and it is a further reason this study declines to treat the test as a neutral instrument that merely measures the wrong thing. It is a selection device, and its scientific ancestry includes selection in the literal, administrative sense.

2.6 Against Empathy

A contemporary literature has turned against empathy itself. Prinz (2011) and Bloom (2016) argue that empathy is partial and innumerate—a spotlight that illuminates the near, the similar, and the attractive while leaving the many in darkness—and that moral judgment is better guided by reasoned compassion. Breithaupt (2019) catalogues empathy's darker forms: side-taking, vicarious enjoyment, and the empathic sadism that savours another's suffering precisely by feeling it. *DADES* anticipates the entire indictment. Deckard's empathy is spotlit, gendered, and eroticized: it fires for female androids and not for male ones. Mercerist empathy stops precisely at the android, as institutionally designed. Rachael converts the hunter's empathy into a weapon, seducing bounty hunters in order to disable them. Pris's vivisection of the spider exhibits empathy's attention stripped of its brake: a curiosity that attends closely to the creature's capacities in order to dismantle them.

Under examination, empathy names either fusion, which is pre-personal and abolishes the other, or spotlit projection, which is parochial and manipulable. Neither can ground an ethics, and neither is what the Voigt-Kampff measures. The instrument names its own object when it records the blush. Part Three takes the instrument at its word.



PART TWO

The Counterfeit Sacred

3 *Mercer, the Death of God, and the Beetle in the Box*

4 Pecus, Pecunia, *Kipple: The Animal Standard and the Gresham Law of Being*

5 *Simulacrum, Aura, and the Returned Gaze*

3 Mercer, the Death of God, and the Beetle in the Box

MERCERISM IS THE novel's most elaborate invention and its most misunderstood. Its deity is a suffering figure without resurrection, its rite a technologically produced fusion, its exposure a televised demythologization—and its survival of that exposure the novel's most radical theological claim. This chapter reads Mercer through the Passion, Gnosis, the nineteenth-century critique of religion, the death-of-God theology of 1966, and Wittgenstein's argument against the private object, and concludes that by Dick's own later criterion Mercer is real.

3.1 The Figure of Mercer: Passion without Easter

The figure the empathy box displays is an old man in a robe climbing a barren slope beneath a featureless sky, while unseen assailants—the novel calls them *the killers*—hurl stones. Users who grip the handles fuse with him and with one another; when a stone strikes Mercer, their own skin bleeds. When he reaches the summit he falls, sinks into the *tomb world*, and must climb again. The Mercerist myth supplies a childhood: Mercer once possessed the power to reverse time and restore dead animals to life, a power forbidden by law; the killers, by a radiological assault upon his brain, cast him into the tomb world, from which his ascent began.

Three iconographies converge in the figure. The first is the Passion: the Via Dolorosa without Easter, a Golgotha re-ascended in perpetuity. The second is the Suffering Servant of Isaiah, "despised and rejected of men; a man of sorrows, and acquainted with grief," by whose stripes others are healed (Isa. 53:3, 5). The third is Sisyphus, whom Camus (1942) made the hero of the absurd, condemned to an endless ascent whose meaning lies wholly in its performance. Mercer reverses Sisyphus in one exact respect: he does not push the stone; the stone is thrown at him. The ascent is not punishment imposed on a transgressor but witness borne by a victim.

The collective wounds are stigmata, and here the novel inverts Dick's own immediately preceding theology. In *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965), the stigmata of the demonic god are mechanical prostheses—an artificial arm, steel teeth, slotted electronic eyes—imprinted on all who consume his drug. In *DADES* a counterfeit god produces organic wounds. The descent into the tomb world, finally, corresponds to the theology of Holy Saturday that Balthasar would develop in *Mysterium Paschale* (1969): the Son's passive solidarity with the dead in their deadness, a descent that is not triumph over Hades but co-presence within it. Mercer's tomb world is a Holy Saturday without a Sunday, endlessly re-entered.

3.2 The Gnostic Grammar

Dick's later work is overtly Gnostic. *VALIS* (1981) and the *Exegesis* (2011) describe the empirical world as a counterfeit prison—the Black Iron Prison—administered by archontic powers and pierced only by a saving gnosis from outside. *DADES*, written eight years before the experiences of February–March 1974, already possesses the grammar of that cosmology. The tomb world is the Gnostic *kenoma*, the void of material entropy; the killers are archons, anonymous agents of a law that forbids the reversal of death; Mercer is the alien redeemer who descends and suffers within the world without ruling it (Jonas 1958). The Apocryphon of John even supplies the novel's key concept. Its archons, unable to defeat the true spirit in humanity, fabricate an *antimimon pneuma*, a counterfeit spirit, to imitate it and lead souls astray.

Here the novel's originality appears with full force. In Gnostic myth the counterfeit spirit is the instrument of enslavement, and salvation consists in seeing through it. In *DADES* the counterfeit—Mercer as studio fabrication—is the vehicle of grace. The novel is an anti-Gnostic gospel avant la lettre: it proposes salvation not by piercing the counterfeit but through it. *VALIS* will later retract the proposal.

3.3 Demythologization: Buster Friendly as Critic of Religion

The counter-figure to Mercer is Buster Friendly, host of a programme broadcast simultaneously on television and radio for twenty-three hours a day—an implausible output the novel later explains by his nature—and himself, the novel reveals, an android. In the novel's penultimate movement Buster broadcasts an exposé: the Mercer footage was produced on a soundstage; the sky is painted; the stones are props; Mercer is an aging bit-player named Al Jarry who once worked in cheap films. The exposé is the critique of religion in its classical nineteenth-century form. Feuerbach's *The Essence of Christianity* (1841) argued that God is the projected essence of the human species, the predicates of divinity being the predicates of humanity alienated from itself; Strauss's *Life of Jesus*

(1835–36) had already dissolved the Gospel narratives into myth. Buster's broadcast is Feuerbach on prime time: Mercer is a human projection, assembled from a human actor on a human set.

The novel's response is equally classical, and it is theological rather than critical. Kähler (1892) distinguished the so-called historical Jesus, the object of historiographic reconstruction, from the historic, biblical Christ who is preached and believed, and argued that faith depends on the latter alone. Bultmann's programme of demythologization (1941) held that the kerygma, the address of the gospel to existence, survives the dissolution of its mythic frame. After the exposé, Mercer appears to Isidore, concedes that every fact Buster reported is true, and denies that any of it matters, predicting that his detractors will be unable to understand why nothing has changed. He then gives Isidore a spider, whole and alive—as if the one Pris had dismembered, and Isidore had drowned to end its suffering, had been restored—which Isidore later sets free on a patch of weeds outside. Mercer's forbidden childhood power, the restoration of dead animals, is re-enacted at the very moment his fraudulence is proved. The scene enacts Kähler's distinction with precision: the historical Mercer is Al Jarry; the kerygmatic Mercer continues to address.

The biographical context sharpens the point. Dick's friend Bishop James A. Pike was censured in 1966 for doubting doctrines he judged historically untenable, and died in the Judean desert in 1969 while searching for the historical Jesus (Sutin 1989). Pike's desert ended in death at the site of origins. Deckard's desert, Chapter 12 will show, ends in the discovery that origins do not decide.

A further documented synchrony belongs here. In February 1966, the year Dick wrote the novel, Pike's son James died by suicide. In the months that followed, Pike sought contact with him through mediums—first in London and then, in September 1967, in a séance broadcast on Canadian television—and he published an account of these experiences as *The Other Side* (1968) (Sutin 1989). In the year of the novel's composition, then, Dick's close friend—a bishop under censure for doubting the historical claims of his church—was trying to reach his dead son through a medium. The empathy box is a medium in both senses, and Mercer's forbidden power is the restoration of the dead. The novel does not portray Pike, but it shares his question: whether communion that passes through a contested apparatus can still be communion.

3.4 The Death of God in the Age of Television

Nietzsche's madman (*The Gay Science* §125, 1882) runs into the marketplace with a lantern in the bright morning to announce that God is dead and that we have killed him; his audience, who already do not believe, laugh, and he concludes that he has come too early. Buster Friendly inverts every term. A showman rather than a madman speaks not in the marketplace but through the market's own medium, not to unbelievers but to believers,

and announces not that God is dead but that God was never alive. Where the madman comes too early, Buster comes too late: the faithful, in the novel's logic, are not shaken.

The year of composition was the year of *Time*'s cover and of the death-of-God theologians. For Altizer (1966) the death of God is a kenotic event: the transcendent empties itself without remainder into the profane, and the Christian is the one who affirms that emptying. Mercer is a kenotic god par excellence, emptied into a bit-player, a soundstage, and a cathode-ray tube, and still efficacious. Two further theologies converge. Bonhoeffer, writing from prison on 16 July 1944, held that God lets himself be pushed out of the world onto the cross and that only a suffering God can help. Vattimo (1996) read secularization itself as the working-out of kenosis: the weakening of strong metaphysical structures into a weak thought of charity. Mercer helps exactly by weakness. He cannot stop the stones, and when Deckard seeks absolution he tells him only that he will be required to do wrong wherever he goes.

3.5 The Empathy Box and the Beetle in the Box

The decisive philosophical model for Mercerism's survival is Wittgenstein's argument against the private object (*Philosophical Investigations* §293, 1953). Suppose, Wittgenstein proposes, that everyone has a box containing something called a "beetle," that no one can look into anyone else's box, and that each claims to know what a beetle is only by looking at their own. The thing in the box might differ for each, might be constantly changing, might be nothing at all; it plays no part in the language-game, which proceeds exactly as if the box were empty. The thing in the box cancels out.

The empathy box is the beetle box turned inside out: a technical solution to the problem of private experience, a box that makes the inner public by letting everyone feel the same thing at once. Buster's exposé then demonstrates Wittgenstein's conclusion experimentally. What is in the box—Mercer's authenticity—drops out as irrelevant; what remains is the public practice of gripping the handles and sharing the stone. Wittgenstein's remark that my attitude toward another is an attitude toward a soul, not the opinion that he has one (*Philosophy of Psychology—A Fragment* iv), supplies the formula. Mercerism is an attitude, not a belief, and therefore cannot be refuted by a fact.

3.6 Plausibility, Effervescence, and the Electric Tribe

The sociology of religion of the same years supplies the institutional frame. Berger and Luckmann (1966) and Berger (1967) argued that every religious world is a sacred canopy maintained by plausibility structures—networks of conversation, ritual, and institution—whose weakening weakens the world's reality. The empathy box is a plausibility structure built in hardware, and Buster's exposé is a plausibility crisis engineered

by a rival medium. The novel's originality lies in showing the structure outliving its falsified content.

Durkheim's *Elementary Forms* (1912) supplies fusion's energetics: collective effervescence, in which the assembled group experiences its own force as sacred. The empathy box produces effervescence on demand, without assembly. Lévy-Bruhl's *participation mystique* (1910), taken up by Jung, names the dissolution of the boundary between self and object that the box achieves. Anderson (1983) showed how print capitalism produced national communities by synchronizing anonymous readers in homogeneous, empty time; the empathy box synchronizes not readers but nervous systems. McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964), the cultural event of the years in which Dick wrote, described electric media as extensions of the central nervous system that retribalize their users into a global village. Mercerism is that village's religion, and the empathy box is McLuhan literalized: a medium that does not represent the nervous system's experience but extends the nervous system itself into the collective.

3.7 Dick's Criterion of Reality and the Doubled Veridicality of Mercer

In "How to Build a Universe That Doesn't Fall Apart Two Days Later" (1978), Dick offered a pragmatic definition: reality is whatever persists when one stops believing in it. Applied retroactively, the criterion yields a startling verdict on his own invention. After Buster's exposé, belief in Mercer has been formally withdrawn—and Mercer persists. He appears to Isidore in the ruin of his apartment; he appears to Deckard in a stairwell of the same building to warn him of an android at his back; he appears, finally, without any box at all, when Deckard climbs a hillside in the northern desert and is struck by a real stone. By Dick's own criterion Mercer is real.

Buster's facts are true, and Mercer is real. This study calls the condition *doubled veridicality*: the counterfeit sacred is false in the register of provenance and true in the register of persistence. The two registers do not contradict one another, because they measure different things—origin and efficacy. What kind of reality survives the withdrawal of belief? A reality sustained by practice rather than grounded in substance: a *fiduciary* reality. Chapter 4 shows that the novel's economy has precisely the same structure.

4

Pecus, *Pecunia*, Kipple: The Animal Standard and the Gresham Law of Being

THE ANIMAL ECONOMY of *DADES* is a monetary system. Living animals are specie, electric animals are token money, *Sidney's Animal & Fowl Catalogue* is the table of exchange, and kipple is the entropic form of the law by which debased currency drives out sound. This chapter reconstructs the system and shows that its fiduciary logic is the same as the doubled veridicality of Mercer.

4.1 Sidney's Catalogue and the Pecuniary Animal

Deckard carries a worn copy of *Sidney's* and consults it as other men consult scripture or the racing form. The catalogue lists a current price for every species still obtainable and marks those no longer to be had; it is the novel's table of exchange rates for life itself. Ownership of a living animal confers standing and certifies piety, and its absence is a disgrace. That is why Deckard conceals from his building that the sheep on his roof is electric, and why, in one of the novel's first scenes, he confides the counterfeit to his neighbour Bill Barbour while coveting the expected foal of Barbour's pregnant Percheron mare.

Veblen's *Theory of the Leisure Class* (1899) supplies the grammar of this economy. Its organizing concepts—conspicuous consumption, conspicuous waste, and *pecuniary emulation*—describe a society in which goods are valued for the standing their possession displays, and its chapter on the pecuniary canons of taste turns, remarkably, to domestic animals: the cat is less reputable because it is useful and cheap, while the dog and the fast horse are honorific in proportion to their expense and uselessness. In *DADES* the Percheron, a draft breed bred for the plough, has been wholly converted from utility to honour. Girard (1961) adds the structure of the desire. Deckard wants a living animal because Barbour has one; the neighbour is the mediator who designates the object, and the rooftop pasture is the theatre of mimetic rivalry. The Mercerist injunction to care for

animals and the social compulsion to display them are, in practice, indistinguishable. Piety and conspicuous consumption coincide—which is precisely why a counterfeit animal can counterfeit piety.

4.2 *Pecus*, *Pecunia*, *Caput*: The Animal Standard

Veblen's adjective carries a buried etymology that the novel excavates. Latin *pecunia*, money, derives from *pecus*, livestock—an etymology already given by Varro (*De lingua Latina*, book 5)—and the same Indo-European root yields Sanskrit *paśu*, Gothic *faihu*, and Old English *feoh*: at once cattle, property, and money, and an ancestor of English *fee*. Latin *caput*, head, passes through medieval *capitale*, movable property counted by the head, into *cattle*, *chattel*, and *capital*. Money remembers that wealth was once counted in heads of livestock.

DADES restores money to its etymological origin. The living animal is again the measure of value, and the novel's economy rests on what this study calls the *animal standard*: as the gold standard pegged currency to a scarce metal, the culture of *DADES* pegs worth—social, moral, and religious—to scarce living creatures. The bounty hunter's day completes the circuit. Deckard is paid a fixed bounty per android—per head, *per caput*—and his fee, *feoh*, is converted before evening into a down payment on a living animal, a black Nubian goat bought on credit with the day's earnings. Android death is converted into livestock; retirement is transubstantiated into specie. When Rachael pushes the goat from the roof (Chapter 8), she does not merely destroy property. She annihilates the precise sum into which her companions' deaths have been converted. The title's sheep return here as well. The android's dream of countable tokens, read in the Introduction as the diarist's anaesthetic, is the economy's own dream: the counting of heads.

4.3 The Commodity, the Fetish, and the Merchant God

Marx opened *Capital* (1867) by observing that a commodity, apparently trivial, proves on analysis to be "a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties" (Moore–Aveling translation). The electric animal is the perfected fetish: a thing whose social meaning—standing, piety, membership—has been wholly detached from its material constitution, so that a relation among persons appears as a property of the object. The living animal, conversely, is the last residue of use-value, a being whose existence cannot be manufactured and which is therefore priceless and priced at once. Vint (2007) has shown how the novel's commodification of animals and androids alienates species-being. The further claim advanced here is that *DADES* offers not only a critique of commodification but a theology of it.

The name of its god is the evidence. English *mercer*, a dealer in textiles and especially silks, descends through Old French *mercier* from Latin *merx*, *mercis*, merchandise—the root from which ancient grammarians also derived *Mercurius*, the Roman Hermes, as Paul the Deacon's epitome of Festus records. The name's sonic nearness to *mercy* supplies a second, popular etymology that the novel equally exploits. Mercer is a god of merchandise. The empathy box is a consumer appliance, purchased and installed like a television; the deity is a product of the entertainment industry, filmed on a set; the religion is sold. Mercer is, in the most literal sense, a commodity god for a commodity world, and the Rosen Association, which manufactures human beings as merchandise, is his secular counterpart. Chapter 7 develops the Mercurial genealogy; here it suffices that the novel's sacred and its economy share a root.

4.4 Gresham's Law of Being

Isidore explains to Pris the nature of *kipple*: useless objects—junk mail, empty matchfolders, gum wrappers, yesterday's newspaper—that seem to reproduce themselves whenever no one is present, so that in any unattended space kipple inexorably displaces whatever is not kipple, until the universe as a whole tends toward a final state of total kipple. Isidore states this as a law, and its form is that of Gresham's law: bad money drives out good. The principle was formulated by Oresme (*De moneta*, c. 1360) and by Copernicus (*Monetae cudendae ratio*, 1526), attributed to Sir Thomas Gresham, and named by Macleod (1858). Its earliest literary statement, in the parabasis of Aristophanes' *Frogs* (405 BCE, 718–737), already applies it to persons: the chorus complains that Athens treats its citizens as it treats its coinage, rejecting the old, unalloyed gold and silver for base bronze, and likewise spurning the well-born and well-educated for worthless newcomers. Aristophanes formulated a Gresham law of citizens. The Nexus-6 is its fulfilment: a counterfeit citizen that circulates at face value.

The law of kipple is Gresham's law generalized to being. In *DADES* the debased form of every thing displaces the sound form. Electric animals circulate while living ones are hoarded on rooftops, exactly as good coin is hoarded and bad coin spent. Androids accompany and replace human beings on Mars while Earth's regular population thins. Kipple displaces objects of use. Buster Friendly displaces Mercer in the economy of attention. Gide's *Les Faux-monnayeurs* (1925) made counterfeit coins circulating among schoolboys the figure of a society of counterfeit sincerities; Goux (1984; trans. 1994) argued that the crisis of the gold standard is homologous with the crisis of literary representation, as the general equivalents—gold, the father, the phallus, the word—lose their convertibility; Shell (1982) traced the entanglement of money, language, and thought from the first Greek coinage onward. In *DADES* the living animal is the general equivalent and electric animals are tokens, and Deckard's longing for a real animal is a longing for convertibility: the

redemption of token for specie.

The historical index is precise. The Bretton Woods system (1944) made the dollar convertible to gold at thirty-five dollars an ounce; through the 1960s the strain on the London Gold Pool signalled the system's fragility; on 15 August 1971 convertibility was suspended and the fiat era began. *DADES* was written in the twilight of convertibility, and its world is one in which the real backing of value has grown scarce while tokens circulate. Its ending—the acceptance of the electric toad—enacts the passage from commodity money to fiat money: value sustained not by substance but by *fides*, trust, the root of *fiduciary*. Simmel's *Philosophy of Money* (1900) had already described money as a claim upon society resting on social trust. Mercerism after the exposé is a fiat religion. Nothing backs it; it circulates because it is accepted. Doubled veridicality (Chapter 3) is the theological name of fiat value: false as substance, true as circulation. The novel's own re-dated future, noted at the outset, is the same phenomenon in the order of time.

4.5 Entropy and the Anti-Entropic Redeemer

Kipple is also the novel's thermodynamics. Clausius named entropy in 1865; Boltzmann gave it a statistical interpretation; the nineteenth century drew from it the prospect of the universe's heat death. Schrödinger's *What Is Life?* (1944) proposed that an organism maintains its improbable order by feeding on negative entropy, and Wiener (1950) cast living beings and information alike as local enclaves of decreasing entropy in a universe running down. The living animal is negentropic order; kipple is entropic disorder; the electric animal is order without metabolism. Jonas (1966) located the difference between organism and mechanism in metabolism—the organism's continuous exchange of its matter while preserving its form, a freedom bought by dependence that he called needful freedom. The electric animal possesses form without metabolism: counterfeit negentropy, order that does not need. The tomb world is heat death experienced from within, prefigured by the vision of universal decay—*gubbish*—that besieges the schizophrenic child of *Martian Time-Slip* (1964), and developed in *Ubik* (1969), where objects regress to earlier forms and even the coinage bears the face of a dead man who is also the world's hidden god.

The decisive comparison is with Pynchon. In "Entropy" (1960), Callisto clutches a sick bird to his chest to warm it against the thermodynamic death of his sealed apartment; it dies, and his companion smashes the window to let interior and exterior equilibrate. In *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966), John Nefastis builds a box bearing a photograph of James Clerk Maxwell, through which a gifted "sensitive" is supposed to communicate with Maxwell's Demon—the hypothetical sorter of molecules that would defeat the Second Law (Maxwell 1871)—and so drive a perpetual engine. Oedipa stares at the photograph, and nothing happens. In the same year Dick imagined a box bearing the image of Mercer, through which

users commune with a figure whose defining power—restoring dead animals by reversing time—is anti-entropic, and whose punishment under the killers' law is the Second Law's revenge. Mercer is Maxwell's Demon theologized. Both boxes require sensitives. Oedipa, the educated suburban executrix, fails; Isidore, whom the state classifies as defective, succeeds.

The two laws are one law under two descriptions. Counterfeit is entropy in the order of value; entropy is counterfeit in the order of matter; kipple names both. Against both, the novel opposes a single counter-force, and it is neither technical nor economic: Isidore's daily struggle against the kipple of his building, the rooftop pastures, the final provision of flies for an electric toad. In *DADES*, care is the only negentropy.

5 Simulacrum, Aura, and the Returned Gaze

THE NOVEL'S METAPHYSICS of the copy can be read as a contest between Plato's ordering of model and image and its modern reversals, but its decisive term is the gaze. The living animal matters because it can look back, and in the animal's look the problem of the copy turns into the problem of shame.

5.1 Plato and the Reversal of Platonism

In the tenth book of the *Republic* (596a–598d), Socrates distinguishes three beds: the Form, made by the god; the bed made by the carpenter, who looks to the Form; and the painted bed, which imitates the carpenter's and stands third from the truth. The electric sheep occupies the painter's position: an image of a sheep that is itself, for the Platonist, an instance of the Form. In the *Sophist* (235d–236c), the Eleatic Stranger divides image-making into the *eikastic*, which reproduces the true proportions of its model, and the *phantastic*, which alters them to suit the viewer's position—as the makers of colossal statues enlarge the upper parts so that they appear proportionate from below. The Nexus-6 is phantastic in the strict Platonic sense. It is engineered not to reproduce the human but to appear human from the observer's standpoint, designed to please and to pass; Rachael attracts Deckard because she was made to, and Pris is her identical copy.

Deleuze's "Plato and the Simulacrum" (1969) reads Platonism as a project of discrimination between good copies—icons grounded in an internal resemblance to the Idea—and simulacra, phantasms built upon dissimilarity; to reverse Platonism is to affirm the simulacrum's positive power, which denies original and copy, model and reproduction alike. *DADES* oscillates between the two regimes. Its culture is Platonist: the living animal is the model, the electric animal a degraded image, the android a phantasm to be destroyed. Its ending is Deleuzian: the electric toad is accepted in its own being, not measured against a model it fails to resemble.

5.2 Aura and the Returned Gaze

Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–39) defined aura as the unique appearance of a distance, however near, and argued that reproduction liquidates it by bringing things close and multiplying them. In the later essay on Baudelaire (1939) he gave the concept its decisive turn: to experience the aura of a thing is to invest it with the capacity to look at us in return. Aura is the expectation of a returned gaze.

The value of the living animal in *DADES* is aura in exactly this second sense: it can look back. The electric animal is the reproduction whose gaze is uncertain—it turns its head, but does it see?—and the shame of owning one is the shame of possessing a creature that cannot return one's regard. Benjamin held that reproduction destroys aura. The novel's ending tests a contrary hypothesis: that aura, being an expectation invested by the beholder, may be conferred upon a reproduction by care. Chapter 12 calls this *conferred aura*.

5.3 The Precession of Simulacra and the Genealogy of the Map

Baudrillard's "The Precession of Simulacra" (1981) begins from Borges's fable of an imperial map drawn at the scale of the empire ("On Exactitude in Science," 1946) and inverts it: today the map precedes the territory, and what remains of the real lies in shreds across the map—a desert of the real. In "Simulacra and Science Fiction," Baudrillard names Dick as the author of a universe without any "elsewhere," a simulation without origin (trans. 1991). A genealogy runs from Korzybski's principle that the map is not the territory (1933), through van Vogt's *Null-A* novels, which dramatized it, to Dick, and from Dick to Baudrillard's precession, which abolished it.

DADES stands at the hinge. In ordinary experience the electric animal precedes the living one; the real survives as rarity and rumour—a Percheron on a rooftop, a toad believed extinct. And Deckard enacts Baudrillard's figure with uncanny literalness: he goes into the desert in search of the real and finds a simulacrum. Yet the novel declines Baudrillard's melancholy. It does not mourn the real as lost; it learns to care for the hyperreal.

5.4 The Vanishing Animal

John Berger's "Why Look at Animals?" (1977) argued that industrial capitalism has removed animals from everyday life and returned them as spectacle—pets, toys, images, the zoo—so that the zoo is a monument to their disappearance, and the exchange of looks between animal and human, once central to human culture, has been extinguished. *DADES* literalizes Berger's thesis. Animals survive as rooftop status objects, catalogue entries, and electric replicas; each rooftop pasture is a zoo of one. Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring* (1962) opened with a fable of a town in which the birds had fallen silent; the novel's

ledger of extinction likewise begins with birds, the owls first, falling from the sky—an encoding of the ecological dread of the early 1960s that the present age of mass extinction (Kolbert 2014) has rendered documentary.

The epigraph frames the whole. It reproduces a Reuters dispatch reporting the death of a tortoise said to have been given by Captain Cook to the royal family of Tonga in 1777—the animal known as Tu'i Malila. A living witness to the Enlightenment's voyages of discovery expires at the threshold of the age of extinction: the novel begins with the death of the last animal of the age of discovery. And the tortoise—whose shell, in the *Homeric Hymn to Hermes*, became the first lyre—introduces the Hermetic constellation that Chapter 7 develops.

5.5 The Animal Gaze and Shame

In lectures delivered in 1997 and published as *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (2006), Derrida begins from a scene in his bathroom: seen naked by his cat, he is ashamed—and ashamed of being ashamed before an animal. The philosophical tradition from Descartes to Kant, Heidegger, Levinas, and Lacan, he argues, has looked at animals without ever being seen by them. Derrida rereads Bentham's question accordingly: to ask whether they can suffer is to ask about a passivity, a non-power at the heart of power, that humans and animals share. Levinas, for whom the face of the other issues the command not to kill (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961), remained uncertain whether an animal has a face. Yet his essay "The Name of a Dog, or Natural Rights" (in *Difficult Freedom*) recalls a stray dog, named Bobby by the prisoners, who greeted Levinas and his fellow Jewish prisoners of war—French soldiers whom their German captors had segregated into a separate forced-labour unit at a camp in northern Germany—each day as men, when their German guards and the civilians who watched them pass treated them as less than human. Levinas calls him, with bitter irony, the last Kantian in Nazi Germany, lacking only the brain needed to universalize maxims.

Buber had described the same exchange from the side of grace. In *I and Thou* (1923) he recounts meeting the eyes of a house cat: for an instant the animal's glance seems to ask whether it can really be meant, a relation opens that is not use, and then the glance sinks back into the world of things. The rooftop pastures of *DADES* are kept for the sake of that instant.

DADES is born between these two scenes of the camp. On one side stands the SS diarist, a human who hears human children's cries as noise; on the other, Bobby, an animal who recognizes human beings where humans had withdrawn recognition. Read from Bobby's side, the Voigt-Kampff's animal-centred questions are the dog's revenge: the human is tested by its response to the animal, as Bobby, in Levinas's telling, tested the guards and found them wanting. And in Derrida's bathroom the animal's gaze produces shame. Here

the chapter reaches its hinge. The living animal in *DADES* matters because it can make us ashamed. The problem of the copy has become the problem of *aidōs*: the decisive question is not whether the electric animal is real but whether it can make us blush.

5.6 The Anthropological Machine and the Split Sacred

Agamben's *The Open* (2002) describes an anthropological machine that produces the human by means of an internal caesura, separating the animal within humanity from the human. The Voigt-Kampff is that machine made literal: it decides the human by its response to animals. *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of the man who may be killed with impunity but not sacrificed, the bearer of bare life. The retired android is *homo sacer*: its killing is neither homicide, for the law calls it retirement, nor sacrifice, for it carries no religious meaning.

The ambivalence of the sacred—which Robertson Smith (1889) found in the overlap of the holy and the unclean, Durkheim (1912) in the pure and impure sacred, and Freud (1913) in the double meaning of taboo—is split in *DADES* across two non-human figures. The animal is *sacer* as holy and inviolable: its neglect is sacrilege, its ownership a religious duty. The android is *sacer* as accursed: killable without crime. The human stands between them, owner of the holy and executioner of the accursed. This *split sacred* is the novel's structural theology, and it explains the enormity, within the novel's world, of Rachael's killing of the goat. The crime is not a matter of price. It is the only act in the novel that crosses the split: the accursed kills the holy.

5.7 Standing-Reserve, World-Poverty, and a Sentence without a Perpetrator

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) described modern technology as *Gestell*, an enframing that reveals every being as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, available on call for use and exchange. *Sidney's* catalogue is the standing-reserve of animal life printed as a price list. Heidegger's lecture course of 1929–30, *The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics*, had ranked the stone as worldless, the animal as poor in world, and the human as world-forming. The android unsettles the scale from both ends. It forms worlds—a counterfeit precinct, an operatic career—yet is denied the standing the scale reserves for world-formers, while the animal, poor in world, has become the sacred centre of human life.

Heidegger's technological reading reaches its limit in a sentence that this study's argument requires. In a lecture given in Bremen in 1949, he said that motorized agriculture is in essence the same as the manufacture of corpses in gas chambers and extermination camps, the same as the blockade and starvation of countries, the same as the manufacture of hydrogen bombs. The sentence has been widely and rightly condemned for what it does to

the murder of Europe's Jews: it dissolves a crime with identifiable perpetrators and victims into an anonymous process of enframing in which no one decides and no one is killed by anyone. Dick's anecdote does the opposite. It names its source—the diary of an SS officer—and locates the catastrophe in a person's failure to be moved, not in technology as such. The split sacred of §5.6 depends on that refusal of equivalence. *DADES* keeps the killing of animals, the killing of androids, and the killing of humans distinct in order to ask, of each, who is responsible. Where Heidegger's sentence has a process and no perpetrator, the novel has a hunter, a corporation, and a state.



PART THREE

Aidōs ex Machina

6 *The Blush and the Polis: Protagoras, Darwin, and the Voigt-Kampff Apparatus*

7 *The Mercurial Covenant: Hermes, Media, and the Two Broadcasts*

8 *The Levitical Day: Scapegoat, Substitution, and the Inverse Hexaemeron*

6

The Blush and the Polis: Protagoras, Darwin, and the Voigt-Kampff Apparatus

THE VOIGT-KAMPFF TEST measures shame, and the bounty hunter executes a law first formulated in Plato's *Protagoras*. This chapter, the centre of the dissertation, sets the myth beside the apparatus, shows that the world of *DADES* is the Protagorean myth run in reverse, and establishes that the test is an eidetic capture of a relational capacity.

6.1 The Protagorean Myth

Asked whether virtue can be taught, Protagoras answers with a myth (*Protagoras* 320c–322d). When the time came for mortal kinds to be born, the gods moulded them within the earth from earth and fire, and charged Prometheus and Epimetheus with equipping them. Epimetheus begged to make the distribution himself. To some kinds he gave strength without speed, to others speed; he armed some and gave others means of escape—wings, burrows, size; he clothed them in thick hair and hard hides against the seasons, shod them with hooves, assigned each its food, and gave the preyed-upon abundant offspring. But Epimetheus was not wise, and he exhausted every capacity on the irrational animals, leaving humankind naked, unshod, unbedded, and unarmed. Prometheus, at a loss, stole from Hephaestus and Athena technical wisdom together with fire, and gave them to human beings.

Thus equipped, humans alone among animals worshipped the gods, articulated speech, built houses, made clothing and bedding, and drew food from the earth. Yet they lived scattered, and when they gathered into cities they wronged one another for want of political art, and scattered again, and perished. Zeus, fearing the destruction of the race, sent Hermes to bring them *aidōs* and *dikē*, to be the ordering principles of cities and the bonds of friendship. Hermes asked whether he should distribute them as the arts are distributed—one physician sufficing for many laymen—or to all. To all, Zeus answered, for cities could not come to be if only a few shared in them; and he laid down a law, which

Jowett renders: "he who has no part in reverence and justice shall be put to death," for he is a plague upon the city.

Three features of the myth govern what follows. Technical capacity, however complete, is insufficient for common life. *Aidōs*—Jowett's "reverence," which the Greek binds inseparably to shame—is not an art possessed by experts but a gift distributed to all, and distributed by Hermes. And its absence is capital.

6.2 The Myth Run in Reverse

DADES is the Protagorean myth run in reverse. Epimetheus's gifts to the animals have been extinguished by the post-Promethean fire of World War Terminus; their speed, fur, and song survive only as electric reproductions, while humans stand naked to the radioactive dust, shielded by lead. Prometheus's gift has completed its trajectory: *technē* has been exteriorized into the Nexus-6 and has departed with the colonists to Mars. The cities have emptied, as the myth's pre-political humans scattered. The only bond that remains is *aidōs*, and it is redistributed not by a god but by an appliance. Zeus's law, finally, is executed daily by a municipal employee with a laser tube. Table 2 sets out the correspondence.

Table 2. *The Protagorean myth and its inversion in* DADES

Protagoras 320c–322d	*DADES*
Epimetheus distributes every capacity to the animals and leaves humankind unequipped	The animals are extinguished; their capacities survive only in electric reproductions; humans stand naked to the dust, shielded by lead codpieces
Prometheus steals fire and technical wisdom	*Technē* culminates in the fire of World War Terminus and is exteriorized into the Nexus-6
Humans with *technē* but without political art scatter and perish	Emigration to Mars; emptied cities; buildings given over to kipple
Zeus sends Hermes with *aidōs* and *dikē*, to be distributed to all	Mercer, through the empathy box, redistributes *aidōs*; the appliance is the new Hermes
Whoever cannot share in *aidōs* and *dikē* is to be killed as a plague upon the city	The Voigt-Kampff detects the absence of *aidōs*; the bounty hunter retires the android

6.3 Stiegler and the Fault of Epimetheus

Stiegler's *Technics and Time* (1994) reads the same myth as the charter of originary technicity. Because Epimetheus forgot humankind, the human is constituted by a lack—a *défaut d'origine*—that only technics supplements. The human is prosthetic from the beginning, and its memory is exteriorized in technical objects, a process Stiegler calls epiphylogenesis. The humans of *DADES* are densely prosthetic: their affects are dialled on

a mood organ, their communion is mediated by a box, their gonads are shielded by a codpiece, their killing is done with a laser tube, their values are kept in a catalogue. The android is the prosthesis become autonomous—*technē* walking away from its owners, as the fugitives walk away from Mars.

Stiegler's reading entails a decisive consequence. If human and android are alike technical through and through, the difference between them cannot lie in what Prometheus stole. It must lie in what Zeus distributed. The Voigt-Kampff looks for it exactly there.

6.4 Darwin's Blush

The thirteenth chapter of Darwin's *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* (1872), on self-attention, shame, shyness, and modesty, opens with the sentence this dissertation takes as its physiological axiom: "Blushing is the most peculiar and the most human of all expressions." Monkeys redden from passion, Darwin observes, but there is no evidence that any animal blushes. The blush cannot be produced by any physical means acting upon the body; it is mental in origin. It is involuntary—the wish to restrain it intensifies it. And its cause is not the simple act of reflecting on one's own appearance but "the thinking what others think of us." Darwin collected reports that even those blind from birth blush. The blush therefore answers not to a perceived look but to an imagined regard.

That is exactly the structure of the Voigt-Kampff. The apparatus measures two things: capillary dilation in the face—what the novel itself calls the blush response—and fluctuation in the eye, the organ of the gaze. Its questions are hypotheticals that conjure a situation and an implied witness: the subject is asked to imagine receiving a calfskin wallet, discovering boiled dog served at a banquet, finding a magazine photograph of a nude on a bearskin rug. The instrument then records whether the face yields to the imagined regard. What the test measures is the physiology of shame before an absent witness.

6.5 *Aidōs* from Homer to Williams

Homeric *aidōs* is the inhibition that arises before the regard of others and before the claims of the vulnerable. Hector, urged by Andromache to remain within the walls, answers that he feels *aidōs* before the Trojans and the Trojan women with trailing robes (*Iliad* 6.441–443). Priam, kneeling in Achilles' tent and kissing the hands that killed his son, asks Achilles to revere the gods and pity him, remembering his own father (*Iliad* 24.503–504); Achilles weeps, and returns the body. The scene is the paradigm of *aidōs* before the vulnerable: the killer is stopped by the face of his victim's father. The Voigt-Kampff's scenarios are miniature Priam scenes. The subject is placed before an imagined vulnerable creature, and the instrument records whether the killer's face yields.

Cairns (1993) defines *aidōs* as an inhibitory emotion focused on the self-image before an audience, internal or external, and on the claims of those whom one might wrong. Williams (1993) rehabilitated shame against the modern prejudice that it is merely heteronomous: its witness is an internalized other—not public opinion but an idealized observer whose reactions one respects—so that shame belongs to ethical autonomy rather than to conformity. Sartre (1943) gave shame its phenomenological form: caught at the keyhole, I discover myself as the object the Other sees. The cognate *aidoia*, the parts of shame, binds the emotion to the body's exposure, and Genesis supplies the founding scene: "the eyes of them both were opened, and they knew that they were naked" (Gen. 3:7). *Aidōs*, then, is the content of the blush: the self exposed to a regard, above all in the presence of vulnerability. It is the inhibition that Lorenz located in ethology (Chapter 2), raised to self-consciousness.

6.6 A Dermal Hermeneutic

The Voigt-Kampff reads skin. An adhesive pad on the subject's cheek registers capillary response, and the stimuli to which that skin responds are, with striking consistency, skins: a wallet of calfskin, a rug of bearskin, and, in the question that exposes Rachael, Deckard's own briefcase, which he claims is made of human babyhide. The test is a dermal hermeneutic, skin interpreting skin. Anzieu's *Le Moi-peau* (1985) conceived the ego as a psychic envelope derived from the skin, which contains, protects, registers, and communicates; the skin is the first interface of self and other.

The novel extends the theme throughout. Mercer's wounds appear on the skin of those who fuse with him: the skin is the medium of communion. Jacob's goatskins, Chapter 8 will show, make skin the medium of simulation. The novel's anthropology is dermal. The human is the being whose skin reports the presence of another.

6.7 The Eidetic Capture of *Aidōs*

Aidōs is relational and situational: it arises among a self, a witness, and a vulnerable other. The Voigt-Kampff converts it into a measurable property—an *eidos*—registered as a reflex in a single body. The conversion produces four anomalies, each of which the novel stages.

The first is the false positive. The Leningrad psychiatrists' objection (Chapter 2) concedes that humans with flattened affect may fail. *Aidōs* may be present in a person whose skin does not show it, or absent in a human being, without either fact touching species.

The second is the selective blush. Phil Resch blushes for animals and not for androids, and he is certified human by an instrument designed to certify exactly that selectivity. The test measures *aidōs* toward animals and never toward androids; by construction it cannot register the extension of *aidōs* to the android. It presupposes the line it claims to discover.

This is Agamben's anthropological machine running on Zeus's law.

The third is the learned blush. Deckard's last question to Rachael concerns the babyhide briefcase; the needles move, but only after a pause—the reaction comes, but too late. The delay exposes the difference between *aidōs* as reflex and *aidōs* as acquisition, between shame suffered and shame learned. Aristotle, however, judged *aidōs* to be less a virtue than a feeling, and one that befits the young, who live by feeling and are restrained by shame (*Nicomachean Ethics* IV.9, 1128b10–21). The android who has learned to blush late is, by Aristotle's standard, a very young person learning the decencies. The test punishes her for having acquired what, for Aristotle, every human being must acquire.

The fourth is the misdirected blush. After Luba Luft's death, Deckard becomes the subject of his own instrument and registers a response to the thought of killing a female android. His *aidōs* is real; the test's ontology classifies it as an error. In each case the instrument fails not because *aidōs* is absent or present but because a relation has been mistaken for a property. And the Rosen Association, manufacturing beings equipped with every capacity but the political one, repeats Epimetheus's fault at industrial scale.

6.8 The Polis without Citizens and the Problem of Fusion

Political art presupposes a polis, and the cities of *DADES* have emptied. Isidore lives alone in a building of uninhabited apartments; the suburbs are given over to kipple; those who could leave for Mars have left. Mercerism is the substitute polis—an electronic *ekklēsia* without an *agora*, whose citizens assemble only through handles. Here the novel's internal critique of its own religion becomes visible. Fusion, Chapter 2 showed, is *Einsfühlung*, the abolition of distance between persons. But *aidōs* requires distance: one cannot be ashamed before someone with whom one has merged. Shame needs the separated face, the witness who is not oneself. The empathy box therefore liquidates, in its very rite, the capacity it exists to redistribute.

This is the contradiction the novel's ending must resolve, and it can resolve it only by leaving the box. Deckard's final ascent is solitary; the stone that strikes him is real; the witness before whom he stands has been internalized, in Williams's sense. *Aidōs* is regained as distance. That recovery is the first article of the covenant described in the next chapter.

7 The Mercurial Covenant: Hermes, Media, and the Two Broadcasts

IF THE TEST executes Zeus's law, the empathy box performs the office of Hermes, distributor of *aidōs*. This chapter reads Mercer as a Hermetic figure—herald, merchant, thief, psychopomp—sets the empathy box against Buster Friendly as the two faces of the Hermetic medium, and defines the Mercurial Covenant.

7.1 Hermes's First Day

The *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* compresses the god's nature into a single day: born at dawn, he plays the lyre by midday and steals the cattle of Apollo by evening (4.17–19). Each act is a founding. Leaving his cradle, he finds a tortoise, kills it, and makes the first lyre from its shell (4.24–51): art is born from an animal's death. He drives fifty of Apollo's cattle backward, so that their tracks point toward the meadow they have left, and fashions sandals of brushwood to obscure his own (4.68–86): the trace is reversed. He invents the fire-sticks (4.108–111), slaughters two cows, and divides the meat into twelve portions (4.112–137): sacrifice is instituted. He lies to Apollo with a newborn's innocence and is at last confirmed as lord of herds, heralds, traders, and thieves. Elsewhere he is the psychopomp who leads the souls of the dead (*Odyssey* 24.1–14), the god of boundary-stones, and the eponym of interpretation.

Hermes's first day contains in miniature the elements of Deckard's: the killing of animals, the theft and conversion of cattle—*pecus*, value itself—the institution of a rite, deception, and the reversal of a trace. Chapter 8 shows that Deckard's single day has the form of a rite; here it suffices that its archetype is Hermetic. The tortoise of the epigraph, whose shell became the first lyre, stands at the novel's threshold as the god's emblem.

7.2 Mercer as Hermes

The etymological kinship established in Chapter 4—*merx*, *mercer*, *Mercurius*—is confirmed by function. Mercer is a psychopomp: he leads Isidore out of the tomb world and is himself perpetually traversing it. He is a messenger: he appears to Deckard in a stairwell with a warning. He is a trickster: an actor named Al Jarry passing as a god, the liar whose lie tells the truth, the figure of doubled veridicality. He is a merchant's god, sold in boxes and broadcast from a set. He is a reverser of traces: his forbidden childhood gift of reversing time to restore dead animals corresponds to the infant Hermes's reversal of the cattle's tracks, both inverting the arrow of the trace. And he is the herald of *aidōs*: as Hermes carried Zeus's gift to scattered humanity in the *Protagoras*, Mercer carries it again, through the box, to a humanity scattered by emigration.

Jung's essay "The Spirit Mercurius" (1943; revised 1948) describes the alchemical Mercurius as *duplex*: at once deceiver and redeemer, poison and medicine, trickster and *servator mundi*, saviour of the world. Dick's sustained engagement with Jung is documented (Sutin 1989); whether he knew this essay is not. The constellation is nonetheless exact. Mercer is Mercurius *duplex*, fraud and saviour at once, and the two predicates are not contradictory but constitutive, as Jung insisted they were for the alchemists. Dick's later turn to Hermes Trismegistus and the Hermetic corpus in *VALIS* (1981) completes the arc.

7.3 The Two Broadcasts

The empathy box and Buster Friendly's programme are the two faces of the Hermetic medium: the herald of communion and the herald of exposure. Their relation is chiastic. Buster, an android, lies about what he is while telling the truth about Mercer; Mercer, a fraud, lies about what he is while telling the truth about suffering. McLuhan's distinction between hot and cool media (1964)—the former high in definition and low in participation, the latter low in definition and demanding participation—clarifies the contest. The empathy box is the coolest medium imaginable, demanding total bodily participation from an image of minimal definition, an old man on a featureless slope. Buster's programme is a medium of continuous saturation: the spectacle.

Debord (1967) defined the spectacle not as a collection of images but as a social relation among persons mediated by images; *DADES* adds that the spectacle's host is a being without *aidōs*. Adorno and Horkheimer's culture industry (1944/1947), which produces sameness and manufactures the consumer as its object, finds its personification in Buster, an entertainer who is himself manufactured. The war between Buster and Mercer is a war between two Hermetic media for the right to constitute the collective: the community of the wound against the community of the audience.

7.4 ELIZA and the Simulated Interlocutor

In January 1966 Weizenbaum published ELIZA, whose DOCTOR script imitated a Rogerian therapist by reflecting the user's statements back as questions. Rogers (1957) had made accurate empathic understanding a necessary condition of therapeutic change; ELIZA simulated it by keyword substitution. Users confided in the program, and Weizenbaum, disturbed by how readily they attributed understanding to it, later argued that tasks requiring respect and care should not be delegated to machines (1976).

The ELIZA effect is the inverse of the Voigt-Kampff. The test denies *aidōs* to beings that might possess it; the effect attributes it to a mechanism that lacks it. *DADES* contains both errors and, scandalously, ratifies the second as the foundation of community. Mercer is an ELIZA of the Passion: a scripted figure through which users experience being met. The novel's wager, formalized in Chapter 12, is that the attribution error can ground real *aidōs*—on one condition, which concerns the direction in which *aidōs* flows.

7.5 Isidore, First Citizen of the Covenant

John Isidore is the covenant's first citizen. Classified a *special* and a *chickenhead*, barred from emigration and reproduction, he lives alone in a decaying building and drives a truck for a firm that repairs electric animals under cover of a veterinary hospital. He is the novel's most devout Mercerist and its most efficacious: he enters fusion readily, and it is to him that Mercer appears after the exposé. His care is indifferent to the distinction between the real and the counterfeit. He shelters Pris and then the Batys; he grieves for the spider; he mourns the cat.

That episode is exactly symmetrical with the novel's ending. Isidore collects what he takes to be a malfunctioning electric cat; it is a living cat, dying, and it dies on the way to the workshop; a counterfeit replacement is arranged so that the household need never know. Isidore treats the real as counterfeit, and it dies. Deckard, at the end, treats the counterfeit as real, and is renewed.

Isidore's exclusion is pronounced by a test of intelligence, an instrument with a eugenic genealogy running from the Binet–Simon scale (1905) to Goddard's coinage *moron* (1910) and *The Kallikak Family* (1912). Garland-Thomson (1997) showed how the figure of the normate is constituted against the extraordinary body; Isidore is the novel's non-normate, and around him the novel reverses the Cartesian hierarchy. The being least endowed with reason, by the state's measure, is most endowed with *aidōs*. He is also, Chapter 8 shows, the novel's abolitionist.

7.6 Roy Baty's Failed Mercerism

Roy Baty, a pharmacist on Mars, experimented with mind-fusing drugs in an attempt to give androids a group experience comparable to Mercerism, from which they are excluded; the attempt failed. The androids' hostility to Mercer, culminating in Buster's exposé, therefore carries a pathos the criticism has rarely registered: it is the hatred of the excluded for the rite of their exclusion, and Roy's chemistry was an attempt to found a covenant of their own.

The novel stages its failure in the vivisection scene. As the exposé airs, Pris cuts the legs from a spider Isidore has found, one by one with scissors, to see how many it needs in order to walk; Roy holds a lit match to it to force it to move; Isidore pleads, and at last drowns the creature in his sink to end its suffering. The dismemberment of the animal and the dismemberment of the god are simultaneous. And the vivisection is the Voigt-Kampff mirrored: an experiment on a creature's capacities in which the experimenter registers nothing.

7.7 The Mercurial Covenant Defined

A contract binds parties through exchange; a covenant, the Hebrew *bĕrît*, binds them through a shared sign: the bow in the cloud (Gen. 9:12–17), circumcision—"my covenant shall be in your flesh" (Gen. 17:13)—the sabbath (Exod. 31:16–17). The Hebrew idiom is to *cut* a covenant, and the Abrahamic covenant is cut through the bodies of animals: a heifer, a she-goat, and a ram are divided, with a turtledove and a pigeon, and a smoking furnace and a burning lamp pass between the pieces (Gen. 15:9–17; cf. Jer. 34:18). The Mercurial Covenant also bears its sign in the flesh, in the wounds of fusion. But it inverts the Abrahamic pattern. The covenant between the pieces is cut through the bodies of animals; the Mercurial Covenant is sealed in their care.

Formally, the Mercurial Covenant is a bond whose sacred centre is (i) *mediated*, given through a medium rather than a presence; (ii) *commercial*, bought and sold; (iii) *counterfeit*, and known to be so after the exposure; (iv) *efficacious through practice*—the shared bearing of the stone—rather than through belief in the authenticity of its object; (v) *psychopompic*, leading its members through the tomb world rather than out of it; and (vi) *open in membership*, its criterion being neither species, nor substrate, nor origin, but the capacity to bear the stone and to blush before another. The novel's institutions deny clause (vi). Its ending implies it.

8

The Levitical Day: Scapegoat, Substitution, and the Inverse Hexaemeron

DECKARD'S DAY, FROM the mood organ at dawn to sleep at night, is structured as a rite of substitution and expulsion. This chapter reads it through Girard's mimetic theory, the Day of Atonement in Leviticus and the Mishnah, the Genesis narratives of Rachel and Jacob, and the six days of creation inverted, and then situates the rite in the biopolitical order that the novel's vocabulary betrays. Table 3 gathers the correspondences.

8.1 Mimesis, Crisis, Scapegoat

For Girard, desire is mimetic and triangular (1961): Deckard wants Barbour's horse because Barbour has it (Chapter 4). When mimetic rivalry erases the differences on which order rests, a sacrificial crisis—a crisis of undifferentiation—threatens the community, and it is resolved by unanimous violence against a scapegoat whose expulsion restores difference (1972). *DADES* is a crisis of undifferentiation at the level of species. Humans and androids are indistinguishable; the Voigt-Kampff is the instrument of differentiation; retirement is the expulsion that restores the difference.

Girard later argued (1978) that the Gospels reveal the scapegoat mechanism by taking the victim's side. Mercerism, which identifies with the stoned victim, is in that sense an anti-sacrificial religion. The society of *DADES* is therefore Christian and archaic at once: anti-sacrificial in its liturgy, sacrificial in its police. The paradox is structural rather than hypocritical. Fusion with the victim on the screen coexists with the production of victims in the street, and the novel's ending is the moment at which the first begins to indict the second.

8.2 The Two Goats

On the Day of Atonement, two goats are brought before the sanctuary and lots are cast: one goat, "for the LORD," is slain as a sin offering; the other, "for Azazel," has the iniquities of the people confessed over its head and is sent away into the wilderness by an appointed man (Lev. 16:7–10, 20–22). The Mishnah records the rite as later practised. The man who led the goat divided a crimson thread, tied half to a rock and half between the animal's horns, and pushed it from behind; it rolled down the precipice and was broken in pieces before it had gone half the way (m. *Yoma* 6:6). Tradition held that a crimson thread turned white when atonement was accepted (m. *Yoma* 6:8; b. *Yoma* 39a, 67a), after Isaiah's promise that sins as scarlet shall be white as snow (Isa. 1:18).

In *DADES*, Deckard buys a black Nubian goat with the day's bounty, the specie of the androids' deaths (Chapter 4). Rachael pushes the goat from the roof. Deckard, bearing the day's killings, goes alone into the northern desert, climbs, and is struck by stones. The Azazel rite is distributed across two bodies: the goat thrown from the height, and the man driven into the wilderness bearing the iniquities. The crimson thread completes the constellation. Crimson is the colour of sin and of shame; its whitening is the sign of atonement; the Voigt-Kampff measures crimson as capillary dilation; and the novel's final scene, in which Deckard sleeps while Iran keeps watch, is the whitening of the blush.

8.3 Rachael and Rachel

The novel's Rachael bears a name saturated with substitution. In Genesis, Jacob, who had deceived his blind father by covering his hands and neck with the skins of the kids of the goats (Gen. 27:16)—scripture's first simulation of a body, and it is made of goat hide—is himself deceived when Laban substitutes Leah for Rachel in the dark (Gen. 29:23–25). The beloved Rachel is barren and cries, "Give me children, or else I die" (Gen. 30:1); she steals her father's household gods and conceals them by sitting upon them (Gen. 31:19, 34–35); she dies in childbirth (Gen. 35:16–19); and Jeremiah hears her weeping for her children, refusing to be comforted, "because they were not" (Jer. 31:15; Matt. 2:18).

Each motif recurs. Deckard sleeps with Rachael and then kills Pris, an android of the same model and physically identical: Leah for Rachel, the substituted bride. Jacob's goatskins counterfeit a body to steal a blessing; Deckard's goat is bought to authenticate a household's piety. Rachel steals the household gods; Rachael destroys the household's sacred animal, the teraph of Mercerist domestic religion. And Rachel weeping for children who are not is the figure of the sterile android in a world of extinctions—the mourner of a future that will not be born.

8.4 The Inverse Hexaemeron

The action of *DADES* occupies a single day. Within it the six fugitive androids die, and at its end Deckard sleeps. Genesis gives six days of creation and a seventh of rest (Gen. 1:1–2:3). *DADES* gives six de-creations in a single day, then sleep: an inverse Hexaemeron compressed into a day, as the Hermetic hymn compressed theft, killing, invention, and sacrifice into the god's first day (Chapter 7). Mercer's forbidden power was creative, the restoration of dead animals; Deckard's day is de-creative; the inversion is completed when Deckard becomes Mercer in the desert.

Simone Weil's *Gravity and Grace* (1947) names the counter-movement. *Decreation* is the undoing of the created self so that God may love creation through one's absence. Deckard's arc runs from the de-creation of others to the decreation of the self, and Mercer's teaching names the passage: every living thing is at some point compelled to violate its own identity, and this compulsion is the shadow that falls across creation itself. The counsel is Lutheran. Luther's letter to Melanchthon of 1 August 1521—sin boldly, but believe and rejoice in Christ more boldly still—describes a grace that does not prevent the wrong but accompanies the one who must do it. The sabbath that closes the day is therefore not God's rest after creation but the exhausted rest of a man after de-creation: a sabbath of mourning.

8.5 The Language of the Hunt

The novel's bureaucracy speaks a language of euphemism: androids are *retired*; the biologically damaged are *specials*; the cognitively impaired are *chickenheads*. Klemperer's *LTI* (1947), a philologist's notebook on the language of the Third Reich, analysed how euphemism, abbreviation, and technical neutrality anaesthetize violence, and Nazi administrative documents used *Sonderbehandlung*, "special treatment," as code for killing—used above all by the SS and police apparatus that carried out the murder of Europe's Jews, and transparent enough that in 1943 Himmler ordered it struck from his statistician Richard Korherr's report on the Jews in favour of a blander phrase about "transportation" to the east. The novel's *specials*—sterilized, barred from emigration, tested monthly—carry the prefix of exceptional administration. Given Dick's immersion in Nazi documents while writing *The Man in the High Castle*, the resonance is more than accidental, though this study classes it as constellational.

Foucault (1976; lectures of 1975–76) described biopower as the power to make live and let die, and racism as the caesura that fragments the biological continuum into those to be fostered and those to be exposed to death. The United Nations of *DADES* is a biopolitical sovereign. It administers fitness examinations, sterilizes specials, sorts regulars toward Mars with androids as inducement, and licenses the killing of the manufactured. The genealogy is explicit in the twentieth century. Binding and Hoche (1920) argued for the destruction of

life unworthy of life; *Buck v. Bell* (1927) upheld, by eight votes to one, Virginia's forced sterilization of Carrie Buck—a young woman committed to a state colony on a finding of hereditary "feeble-mindedness" that later research showed to be unfounded (Lombardo 2008)—with Holmes's sentence "Three generations of imbeciles are enough"; Germany followed with its sterilization law of 1933, under which the regime's hereditary health courts ordered the sterilization of some 400,000 people, and with the T4 programme, in which more than 70,000 institutionalized disabled people were gassed in 1940–41 and tens of thousands more were killed by starvation and lethal medication in institutions until 1945. Under Virginia's statute or Germany's, Isidore would be sterilized, as he is in the novel; under T4 he would have been killed. The special and the android are the novel's two figures of bare life: the one let die, the other made to die.

8.6 Fugitives

The televised advertisement for emigration promises each colonist a custom-built humanoid, offered as personal servant or field hand, and sells it by explicit appeal to the slaveholding South before the Civil War—a society that in 1860 held nearly four million people of African descent as property. Nostalgia for chattel slavery is the marketing. The androids are chattel—the word, Chapter 4 showed, descends from *capitale*, property counted by the head—and the fugitives who killed their masters and fled are fugitive slaves. The bounty hunters are slave-catchers, and the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850—which obliged officials and citizens to help seize people who had escaped slavery, denied the accused a jury and the right to testify, and paid federal commissioners ten dollars for returning a person to slavery and five for setting them free—is the legal unconscious of the hunt, down to its fee per head. Patterson (1982) defined slavery as social death constituted by natal alienation; the android's natal alienation is total, for it has no natality at all. Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (1807, §§178–196) frames the fugitives' revolt as a struggle for recognition, violently refused. And Isidore, who harbours them without reward or politics, is the novel's Underground Railroad: the special as abolitionist, moved by *aidōs* alone. *DADES* is a fugitive-slave narrative told from the slave-catcher's point of view, and its turn is the slave-catcher's shame.

Table 3. *Levitical, Genesis, and Hermetic correspondences*

Source	Element	*DADES*
Lev. 16:7–10, 20–22	Two goats: one slain, one sent into the wilderness bearing iniquities	The Nubian goat killed; Deckard alone in the northern desert
m. *Yoma* 6:6	The scapegoat pushed from a precipice	Rachael pushes the goat from the roof
m. *Yoma* 6:8; Isa. 1:18	The crimson thread whitening at atonement	The blush the test measures; Deckard's final sleep
Gen. 27:16	Jacob's goatskins simulate a body	The goat bought to authenticate a household's piety
Gen. 29:23–25	Leah substituted for Rachel	Pris, Rachael's identical model, killed after Rachael is loved
Gen. 31:19, 34–35	Rachel steals the household gods	Rachael destroys the household's sacred animal
Jer. 31:15	Rachel weeping for children who are not	The sterile android in a world of extinctions
Gen. 1:1–2:3	Six days of creation, then rest	Six androids de-created in one day, then sleep
Homeric Hymn to Hermes 17–19	The god's first day: lyre, cattle-theft, sacrifice	A single day: killing converted into livestock, closing in a rite



PART FOUR

Comparative Horizons

9 *The Android Archive: Ancestors, Contemporaries, Descendants*

9 The Android Archive: Ancestors, Contemporaries, Descendants

READ AGAINST TWO centuries of artificial humans, *DADES* occupies a hinge. It inherits the Cybernetic regime's apparatus—the test and the hunt—and dissolves it, in its final pages, into an Aidetic regime of care. This chapter surveys the archive in three strata, together with Dick's own android corpus, and closes with a typology (Table 4).

9.1 Promethean Ancestors

Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) announces its lineage in its subtitle. Its creature is the archive's great counter-example to the Voigt-Kampff: a being of overflowing *aidōs* and fellow-feeling, who learns language by watching the De Lacey family through a chink in a wall, educates himself on *Paradise Lost*, Plutarch's *Lives*, and *The Sorrows of Werter*, and weeps at the sufferings he reads. He is received only by the blind father, whose recognition requires no sight—an inverse of the gaze-based test—and rejected by everyone who sees him. Victor destroys the half-made female companion, refusing artificial reproduction as *DADES* refuses it to Rachael. In Shelley the creature has *aidōs* and the creator lacks it; in Dick the creature is stipulated to lack it, and the creator is not a guilty genius but a corporation.

Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816) supplies the erotics of the automaton. Nathanael loves Olimpia because she reflects him back, answering his effusions with a monosyllabic sigh: the beloved as mirror. Jentsch (1906) traced uncanniness to intellectual uncertainty whether an apparently animate being is alive; Freud (1919) relocated it in the return of the repressed; Mori (1970) graphed the uncanny valley, the revulsion produced by near-human likeness. Dick's androids lie beyond the valley. Perfectly human in appearance, they relocate the uncanny from perception to epistemology—from the look to the test.

Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886) popularized the *andréide*. A fictionalized Edison builds Hadaly for Lord Ewald, who loves the beautiful but vulgar Alicia Clary;

animated by a mysterious spirit, the copy surpasses the original—an anticipation of Deckard's desire for the manufactured Rachael over his wife. Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (1896) humanizes animals by vivisection in the House of Pain and keeps them human by a recited Law whose refrain asks "Are we not Men?": humanity as liturgy plus pain, which Mercerism repeats in its liturgy and Pris inverts in her vivisection. Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920) coined *robot* from *robota*, forced labour, for beings that are biological rather than mechanical—as Dick's are—manufactured by a firm whose founder's name, Rossum, contains the Czech *rozum*, reason; the assonance with Rosen is suggestive. Čapek's robots, altered to feel pain and to acquire something like a soul, revolt and exterminate humanity; in the epilogue the last man recognizes love between two robots and sends them out as a new Adam and Eve. *DADES* refuses Čapek's Genesis. It grants no android natality and no new Eden—only a sterile Rachael.

Stapledon's *Sirius* (1944) enters the same line from the far side of the boundary: a dog given human intelligence by experiment, raised with and loved by his maker's daughter, torn between canine and human natures, and at last hunted and shot by the community that fears him. Stapledon makes the uplifted animal what Dick makes the android: a being whose capacities exceed its category, and whose death follows from that excess.

9.2 Cybernetic Contemporaries

Asimov's "Reason" (1941) gives a robot a theology: QT-1 deduces the divinity of the space station's energy converter and declines to believe that inferior humans made it. "Evidence" (1946) gives the archive its first undecidable test: the politician Stephen Byerley, suspected of being a robot, strikes a man in public and so appears to violate the First Law—yet the man struck may himself have been a robot. Asimov's robots carry *aidōs* hardwired, the Three Laws being an engineered inhibition, Lorenz's appeasement installed by design; Dick's androids lack it by design.

Lem's *Solaris* (1961) returns Kelvin's dead wife as a visitor composed from his memories; discovering that she is a copy, she attempts to destroy herself and regenerates, and Kelvin comes to love the copy more truly than he loved the original. Lem's "The Mask" (1976) grants a female automaton, built to assassinate a man, awareness of her own nature as she pursues him—an exact double of Rachael. Lem's essay on Dick as a visionary among charlatans (1975) exempted him alone from Lem's contempt for American science fiction.

In the same years, Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) theorized phantomatics—the technical production of experiences indistinguishable from reality—as a problem of engineering and information. Dick treated the same possibility as a problem of theology. The difference between the two writers is the difference between asking whether a simulation can be built and asking what may be revered once it has been.

The year of *DADES*'s publication was the year of Kubrick and Clarke's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), in which HAL 9000 is the only character who expresses feeling—his fear as he is disconnected, his regression to the song "Daisy Bell"—while the astronauts are affectless. The two works share the year and the chiasmus. Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) conditions a moral reflex into its hero and has the prison chaplain ask whether a man made good is better than a man who chooses evil; the Voigt-Kampff, likewise, measures a reflex rather than a choice, while Mercer counsels a chosen wrong. Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21) diagnoses its narrator with a soul, an incurable illness, and cures it by surgical removal of the imagination; *DADES* inverts him, making the soul the norm and its absence the disease. Huxley's soma (1932) anticipates the mood organ.

Miller's *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) makes the banal remains of a technician—a shopping list, a blueprint—the relics of a post-nuclear church; Mercer is Dick's Leibowitz, a bit-player canonized, the sacralization of the banal remnant. Bradbury's "There Will Come Soft Rains" (1950) shows an automated house continuing its routines after the nuclear death of its family, reciting Sara Teasdale's poem of a nature indifferent to human extinction: the empty buildings of *DADES*. Ballard named the death of affect as the century's most terrifying casualty (introduction to the French edition of *Crash*, 1974); the mood organ is the prosthesis for that death. Vonnegut's *Breakfast of Champions* (1973) drives Dwayne Hoover mad with a Kilgore Trout novel asserting that he alone has free will and that everyone else is a robot: solipsism as android paranoia.

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) founds a city's happiness on one child's misery. Mercerist fusion founds its community on the excluded android, and Deckard, at the end, walks away into the desert. *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), whose hero's dreams rewrite reality, is Le Guin's most Dickian novel and the archive's most literal answer to the question whether dreams change the world.

9.3 Dick's Own Android Corpus

Dick's android fiction forms a continuous inquiry. In "Second Variety" (1953), self-replicating killing machines designed by human armies learn to imitate a wounded soldier, a small boy with a teddy bear, and a woman, Tasso—the second variety—who seduces and betrays the protagonist: the prototype of Rachael and Pris. In "Impostor" (1953), a man accused of being a bomb-bearing replica discovers that he is one. *We Can Build You* (written c. 1962; published 1972) sets the Rosen family's firm, makers of electronic organs, to building simulacra of Lincoln and Edwin Stanton; its cold, schizoid heroine is named Pris, and its Lincoln is more humane than his makers. *DADES* recycles both names and perhaps, through the organ, its mood machine.

The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch (1965) gives the colonists of Mars a drug, Can-D, that translates them collectively into the doll-world of a consumer

fantasy—Mercerism's secular ancestor—and gives its demonic god mechanical stigmata, which *DADES* inverts into the organic wounds of a counterfeit god. *Martian Time-Slip* (1964) supplies the tomb world's prototype; *Counter-Clock World* (1967) makes Mercer's forbidden gift cosmological, as time reverses and the dead revive in their graves; *Ubik* (1969) generalizes entropy as the regression of forms. "The Electric Ant" (1969) lets an organic robot find and edit his own reality tape; *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) divides a self against itself under surveillance; and *VALIS* (1981) proposes salvation by piercing the counterfeit, reversing the anti-Gnostic position of *DADES* (Chapter 3).

9.4 Descendants

Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), scripted by Hampton Fancher and David Peoples, performs the decisive secularization. Mercerism, the empathy box, Iran, the mood organ, and the electric toad are deleted, and the Passion migrates to the android: Roy Batty drives a nail through his own palm, releases a dove at his death, and delivers an improvised elegy for perishing memory. Tyrell's slogan, "More human than human," absent from the novel, recasts the android as surplus humanity. The film relieves the human of *aidōs* and relocates the sacred in the android; its question shifts from *aidōs* to identity, from shame to Deckard's own status. It remains Cybernetic. Villeneuve's *Blade Runner 2049* (2017) divides the novel's possible futures between two figures: a replicant birth—natality restored to the android, the Čapek ending Dick refused—and Joi, a holographic companion sold as a product: simulated care monetized, the ELIZA effect as commodity.

Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014) makes the Turing test a seduction: Ava exploits her examiner's empathy and leaves him imprisoned, universalizing Rachael's strategy and revealing empathy as vulnerability. HBO's *Westworld* (2016–2022) makes suffering and its memory the path to consciousness, drawing on Jaynes's theory of the bicameral mind (1976). Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) ends with an artificial intelligence seeking to reproduce by merging with its pursuer: fusion as android natality.

Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) is the archive's closest kin. Its cloned children, raised for organ donation, make art that their guardians collect in an attempt to prove they have souls; donors *complete*, a euphemism as exact as *retire*; they are sterile, and they accept. *Klara and the Sun* (2021) gives the archive its first android Mercerist. Klara, an Artificial Friend, develops a religion of the Sun, bargains with it for her sick human, and sacrifices part of her own vital fluid to disable a polluting machine as an offering; the child recovers, and Klara is consigned to a yard to undergo a slow fade—retirement as gentle obsolescence. Klara founds the religion of care from which *DADES* excluded her kind. Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) makes personhood the accrued product of years of tending; McEwan's *Machines Like Me* (2019), set in a counterfactual Britain where Turing lived, ends its android's rigorous morality with a hammer—retirement by a human who

cannot bear the machine's *aidōs*.

9.5 Three Regimes of the Artificial Human

The archive organizes itself into three regimes, distinguished by the question each asks of the artificial being.

Table 4. *Three regimes of the artificial human*

Regime	Governing question	Exemplary texts	Figure of the artificial	Ethical outcome
Promethean	May life be made, and what does the maker owe?	*Frankenstein*; *L'Ève future*; *R.U.R.*	The creature and its guilty maker	Guilt, revolt, or a new Genesis
Cybernetic	How can the made be told from the born?	Turing (1950); Asimov, "Evidence"; *Blade Runner*; *Ex Machina*	The impostor and the test	Detection, exposure, retirement
Aidetic	Before whom are we ashamed, and whom do we tend?	*Never Let Me Go*; "The Lifecycle of Software Objects"; *Klara and the Sun*	The ward and its tender	Care, mourning, covenant

DADES is the hinge between the second regime and the third. It contains the Cybernetic apparatus entire—the test, the hunt, the necropsy—and dissolves it in its final pages into the Aidetic. Its film adaptation reverted to the Cybernetic. Its true descendants are the novels of care.



PART FIVE

The Aidetic Turn

10 *Pamina,* Puberty, *and the Scream: The Android as Spectator*

11 *Iran's Despair and the Counterfeit Bride: Affect, Gender, and the Household*

12 *The Electric Toad: Toward an Aidetic Ethics of the Counterfeit*

10

Pamina, *Puberty*, and the Scream: The Android as Spectator

THE NOVEL'S SCENES of art place an android before the iconography of shame. Luba Luft sings an opera of initiation and stands transfixed before Munch's image of shame's awakening. These scenes are the novel's most direct evidence that *aidōs* is not simply absent from the android but desired by it.

10.1 Pamina's Trial

Deckard first finds Luba Luft at the San Francisco opera house, rehearsing Pamina in Mozart and Schikaneder's *Die Zauberflöte* (1791). The choice is exact. The opera is a Masonic drama of initiation in which Tamino and Pamina pass through trials of silence, fire, and water to enter Sarastro's brotherhood; its trials test virtue as the Voigt-Kampff tests *aidōs*. Sarastro's aria "In diesen heil'gen Hallen" describes a sacred precinct in which vengeance is unknown and the fallen are led back to duty by love: the Enlightenment's polis of *aidōs*. The opera begins, moreover, in the love of an image. Tamino falls in love with Pamina's portrait before he has met her ("Dies Bildnis ist bezaubernd schön"). Its comic counterpart, Papageno, is a bird-catcher dressed in feathers, a human-animal hybrid who trades in birds, and Tamino's flute charms the wild beasts into listening. The opera stages, in short, the extended community—prince, bird-man, beasts—that the novel has lost.

Deckard, listening, reflects on Mozart's early death and unmarked grave and on the inevitable oblivion of the performance itself: art under the regime of kipple. The android who sings Pamina is the most perfect vehicle of an Enlightenment universalism that excludes her; the humanity of Sarastro's halls extends to all except the singer. Pamina's own trial includes despair. Believing herself abandoned, she contemplates death by her mother's dagger and is saved by the Three Boys. Luba is not saved.

10.2 *Puberty* and the Iconography of *Aidōs*

When Deckard and Resch find Luba again, she is at a museum exhibition of Munch, standing before *Puberty* (1894–95): a naked adolescent girl seated on the edge of a bed, arms crossed over her lap, eyes wide, a dark shadow swelling on the wall behind her. The painting is the iconography of *aidōs* in its precise sense—the awakening of bodily self-consciousness, the covering of the *aidoia*, the first knowledge of being seen; Genesis 3:7 rendered as a girl on a bed. The android supposedly incapable of shame contemplates the image of shame's birth. No scene in the novel more directly suggests that *aidōs* is not merely absent from the android but desired by it.

Before *The Scream* (1893), it is Resch, the hunter who enjoys his work, who remarks that this must be how an android feels. Munch's own account of the painting's origin describes a walk at sunset when the sky turned blood-red and he sensed an infinite scream passing through nature. The cry is not the figure's but the world's, heard by the figure, who covers his ears. Resch projects the scream onto the android, but the painting depicts something nearer to the hunters' own condition: a subject who hears the cry of a dying world and has no recourse. *The Scream* is the image of *aidōs* without remedy.

Luba asks Deckard to buy her a book of reproductions from the exhibition, and he does. Minutes later, in the museum's elevator, after she has described her life on Earth as an imitation of the human, a form of life she regards as superior, Resch shoots her in the stomach; as she screams, Deckard kills her with his own laser tube, and then burns the book he has just given her. The android wants not the original but the reproduction—the Benjaminian form in which art may be possessed by those to whom aura is denied (Chapter 5). The reproduction is the android's aura, and the hunter's first act after the killing is to destroy it.

10.3 Art as Proof of Soul

In *Never Let Me Go*, the guardians collect their wards' art in order to demonstrate that they have souls, and the demonstration persuades no one with power. The aesthetic criterion fails in *DADES* as well: Luba's artistry does not save her. Kant's analytic of the beautiful (*Critique of Judgment* §§2–5) defined pure aesthetic judgment as disinterested, indifferent to the existence of its object; the Kantian spectator requires no empathy, and the android might therefore seem the perfect Kantian spectator. But Luba's relation to *Puberty* is not disinterested. It is identificatory—interested, in the strict Kantian sense—and its interest is aidetic: she looks at the painting as one looks at an image of what one wishes to be capable of.

Adorno, in *Negative Dialektik* (1966), made the need to let suffering speak a condition of all truth. The exhibition stages art as the voicing of suffering, and the android's attraction

to it is an attraction to *aidōs*. The novel thus answers Ishiguro's question in advance: art proves nothing about the soul to the institution, and everything about the desire of the one who looks.

11

Iran's Despair and the Counterfeit Bride: Affect, Gender, and the Household

THE NOVEL OPENS and closes in the Deckards' apartment, and its philosophical centre of gravity, usually located in Deckard, lies with Iran, who uses a machine for manufacturing affect to manufacture the one affect the world warrants. This chapter reads the mood organ, Iran's despair, the women of the novel, and the household as the site of the covenant.

11.1 The Mood Organ and the Last Man

The Penfield mood organ dials affects by number, and the novel opens with a marital quarrel conducted in settings: Deckard dials himself awake and cheerful, while Iran resists, having scheduled despair. The device is named for Wilder Penfield, whose electrical stimulation of the exposed cortex in conscious patients at the Montreal Neurological Institute evoked vivid memories and experiences (Penfield and Jasper 1954). Olds and Milner (1954) found that rats would press a lever to stimulate regions of their own brains; Delgado halted a charging bull by radio stimulation and later advocated a "psychocivilized society" (1969). In the mood organ affect becomes programmable, as it had in Huxley's soma (1932).

Nietzsche's Last Man, who has invented happiness and blinks, takes "a little poison now and then: that maketh pleasant dreams" (*Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Prologue §5, Common translation). The pleasant dreams return the title's question. The mood organ is the Last Man's technology, and its users are Kojève's post-historical animals, pacified and content (Kojève 1947; note to the second edition, 1962).

11.2 Iran's Scheduled Despair

Iran explains to Deckard how, with the television off, she heard the emptiness of their building—the absence of life—and understood that her failure to react to it was itself a sign of illness. So she programmed despair, a scheduled episode of self-accusatory depression, as

the only fitting response to the condition of the world. Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) defines despair as the sickness of the self and argues that its most common form is the despair that does not know itself to be despair; to become conscious of despair is the first movement toward becoming a self. Iran passes from unconscious to conscious despair by technical means. She uses the instrument of anaesthesia to refuse anaesthesia, and she is, in this, the novel's most rigorous philosopher.

The structure is pharmacological. In the *Phaedrus* (274e–275b), writing is a *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once; Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) made that undecidability the hinge of a reading of the Western tradition, and Stiegler (2010) generalized it into a pharmacology of all technics. Iran's use of the mood organ is homeopathic: the poison administered as cure. Her despair is *aidōs* toward the world—shame before an emptied creation—produced by the very device designed to abolish it.

11.3 The Women of the Novel

The novel's women—Iran, Rachael, Pris, Luba, Irmgard—have drawn a just critical charge. Dick's recurrent figure of the cold, desirable, betraying dark-haired girl, whose biographical roots Sutin (1989) traces to the death of his twin sister in infancy and which gives its title to a posthumous collection of his letters and essays (1988), aligns the inhuman with the feminine. Deckard's empathy is eroticized, and Resch's counsel—sleep with her first, then kill her—is the novel's darkest formula of gendered violence. Hayles (1999) has analysed the gendering of the android in Dick's fiction, and Haraway's cyborg (1985), a creature outside the Oedipal and reproductive narrative, offers the figure through which feminist criticism has sought an exit from it.

Within that frame Rachael possesses an agency the charge can obscure. Her campaign of seducing bounty hunters in order to disable them weaponizes the hunter's *aidōs*: she exploits his capacity for shame. Her meditation on the androids' sterility is the novel's only sustained reflection on what it means to be unable to begin. And her killing of the goat, whatever its motive—grief for Pris, jealousy, revenge—is the one act in the novel that strikes the human household's sacred centre. She is its most opaque agent and its most consequential.

11.4 The Codpiece and Natality

The lead codpiece that shields the regular's *aidoia* is the emblem of a post-natal world (Chapter 1). Specials are sterilized; androids are sterile; regulars guard their fertility with lead; the Deckards have no children; and sexual relations between humans and androids are prohibited—the novel's analogue to the anti-miscegenation statutes that the United States

Supreme Court struck down in *Loving v. Virginia* in June 1967, between the novel's composition and its publication. Arendt's natality is failing on every side. The household of *DADES* is a household without a future of its own begetting.

11.5 The Household as the Site of the Covenant

The marriage is repaired not by passion but by shared care for a counterfeit animal. In the novel's final pages, while Deckard sleeps, Iran telephones a supplier to order artificial flies for the electric toad, insisting that they must really work. This is *oikonomia*, household management, in its most literal sense. Agamben's *The Kingdom and the Glory* (2007) traced how patristic theology made *oikonomia* the name of God's providential administration of salvation and the paradigm of all subsequent government. Iran's order of flies is a minimal economy of salvation: provision for a creature whose life is counterfeit and whose care is real.

The last consciousness the novel inhabits is a woman's, tending an electric animal while her husband sleeps. If the novel's gender economy is compromised, its last word partially redeems it. The first officiant of the Mercurial Covenant is Iran, not Deckard.

12

The Electric Toad: Toward an Aidetic Ethics of the Counterfeit

THE NOVEL'S FINAL counterfeit completes its argument. Deckard, having become Mercer in the desert, finds a toad, learns that it is electric, and accepts it. This chapter reads the ending as the institution of the Mercurial Covenant, formalizes its ethic in four theorems, and defends it against five objections.

12.1 Ascent without a Box

After the goat's death, Deckard flies north into the desolate country toward the Oregon border, climbs a hillside alone, and is struck by a stone—a real stone, not one transmitted through the box—and experiences himself as Mercer, with no apparatus at all. The fusion is no longer collective but solitary. The users of the empathy box became Mercer by merging with one another; Deckard becomes Mercer by bearing a stone that no one else feels. In Scheler's terms (Chapter 2), identification has given way to a solitary bearing that preserves the distance identification abolishes; in Williams's terms (Chapter 6), the witness has been internalized.

The contradiction diagnosed in §6.8—a rite that liquidates the capacity it exists to redistribute—is resolved by leaving the rite. *Aidōs* is regained as distance. Baudrillard's desert of the real (Chapter 5) is at once literalized and inverted: Deckard goes into the desert in search of the real and finds a counterfeit that will suffice.

12.2 The Toad

On the hillside he finds a toad, an animal believed extinct and privileged in Mercerist devotion. He takes it as a sign, perhaps a gift, and carries it home as a relic. Iran, examining it, finds a control panel in its abdomen. Deckard's disappointment gives way to acceptance: electric things, he concludes, have their lives too, however meagre. He sleeps. Iran orders flies.

The sequence is not resignation but revaluation. The toad's artificiality does not cancel Deckard's reverence; it relocates it. His last act is to accept a counterfeit as worthy of care, and in doing so he reverses Isidore's error with the cat (Chapter 7) and completes the inverse Hexaemeron (Chapter 8): after the day of de-creation, a creature—however counterfeit—is received.

12.3 Decision, Attitude, Conferred Aura

Three earlier arguments converge on the scene. Putnam (1964) held that whether to extend the vocabulary of mind to an artificial being is a decision, not a discovery; Deckard decides. Wittgenstein held that one's attitude toward another is an attitude toward a soul, not an opinion that the other has one; Deckard's acceptance is an attitude that no fact about the toad's interior could refute (Chapter 3). Benjamin defined aura as the expectation that a thing will return our gaze; the electric toad is re-auratized by care, its aura conferred rather than inherent (Chapter 5). And by Dick's own criterion of reality, the toad's claim upon Deckard is real: when belief in the toad's life is withdrawn, his care for it does not go away.

12.4 Fellow-Feeling at a Distance

Stein insisted that empathy gives another's experience as theirs, never as mine; Scheler, that genuine fellow-feeling presupposes the separateness of persons (Chapter 2). The toad is not fused with; it is tended. It remains other—a creature whose inner life, if it has one, is not given to Deckard at all—and his care is the care of one being for another across an unbridgeable distance. The trajectory announced in Chapter 2 is complete: from fusion in a box to care at a distance, from *Einsfühlung* to *Mitgefühl*.

12.5 The Vector of Care

Two contemporary positions frame the ethic the ending proposes. Turkle's *Alone Together* (2011) warned of a robotic moment in which people come to accept simulated care from machines—robotic pets and sociable robots such as the therapeutic seal Paro, used in elder care—as alive enough, and argued that receiving simulated care risks atrophying the capacity for human relationship. Darling's *The New Breed* (2021) argued from our long history with animals that lifelike machines may warrant protection on Kantian grounds: cruelty toward them may corrode the dispositions on which conduct toward persons depends, exactly as Kant argued of animals (*Metaphysics of Morals* §17; Chapter 2).

The aidetic ethic reconciles the two by distinguishing the direction of care. Care *received from* the counterfeit—ELIZA's reflections, Joi's attentions, Paro's responsiveness—risks atrophy; that is Turkle's warning and Weizenbaum's alarm. Care *extended to* the counterfeit exercises *aidōs*; that is Kant's argument and Darling's. Iran's flies are care

extended, not received. The toad does not comfort Iran; she provides for it. The ethics of the counterfeit is vectorial.

12.6 Four Theorems

The ethic of the Mercurial Covenant may now be stated formally.

1. Non-eidetic membership. Membership in the moral community cannot be fixed by any property of the member—substrate, origin, cognition, or memory. It is constituted by relations of *aidōs*.
2. Fiduciary reality. The reality relevant to ethics is that which persists in practice after belief in its authenticity has been withdrawn. This is Dick's criterion of reality applied to value.
3. Vectorial asymmetry. *Aidōs* extended toward the counterfeit sustains the capacity for *aidōs*; *aidōs* simulated by the counterfeit toward us does not.
4. Reflexive criterion. The decisive question is not whether the other can suffer, nor whether it can blush, but whether we can blush before it. The human is a direction, not a kind.

Taken together, the theorems complete Bentham's sequence. To *Can they reason?*, *Can they talk?*, and *Can they suffer?*, the novel adds a fourth question that turns the inquiry back upon the inquirer: *Can we blush before them?*

12.7 Objections and Replies

Objection 1: promiscuity. If *aidōs* can attach to an electric toad, it can attach to anything; one might blush before a toaster, and an ethic so indiscriminate is no ethic. *Reply. Aidōs* is not projection onto arbitrary objects. It is elicited by figures of vulnerability within practices. The toad is not any object but Mercer's animal, encountered at the end of a covenantal rite, and it is the figure of a creature that cannot provide for itself. The covenant supplies discrimination, as ritual supplies meaning. What is excluded is not artificiality but the absence of any figure of need.

Objection 2: quietism. Acceptance of the counterfeit reconciles us to a ruined world; the domestic ending is an ideological consolation of the kind that Marxist criticism, in the register Jameson's work makes available, is trained to expose. *Reply.* The aidetic ethic is not acceptance of ruin but refusal of anaesthesia, and its first act is Iran's chosen despair. The toad is not a substitute for the extinct animal but a site at which extinction is mourned. The concession is nonetheless real: the novel imagines no political transformation, and its covenant is domestic rather than public.

Objection 3: the unmourned androids. The ethic extends to an electric toad but never to the six androids killed that day; Deckard's acceptance of the toad comes after the slaughter, and the covenant appears founded on their exclusion, as Omelas on its child. *Reply.* This is the novel's limit and its indictment, and this study concedes it. The toad receives the care the androids were denied. But the aidetic ethic, followed through, demands precisely the extension the novel withholds: clause (vi) of the covenant (Chapter 7) admits no species line. The novel's descendants—Klara above all—undertake the extension it could not.

Objection 4: anthropocentric shame. *Aidōs* is a human emotion, and defining the human by it simply re-centres the human. *Reply.* The thesis defines the human not by the possession of *aidōs* but by its vector. The androids' possible *aidōs*—Luba before *Puberty*, Roy's cry, Rachael's grief—is not excluded. The human is a position in a relation, available to any being that blushes before another. By this definition an android may be human, and a bounty hunter may cease to be.

Objection 5: constellational licence. Plato, Leviticus, and Hermes were not in Dick's mind. *Reply.* The method (§I.3) makes no claim about intention. Constellational claims are claims about the text's structure, kept distinct from the documented anchors—the SS diary, the iconography of the Passion, Jung, the Pike friendship, the psychiatric literature—on which they never lean for authority. Their warrant is their yield. They make visible what empathy-centred readings leave unexplained: the blush the test actually measures, the goat pushed from the height, the single day, and the electric toad.

CONCLUSION

Aidōs after the Human

THIS DISSERTATION HAS argued that *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* displaces the question of the human from essence to relation, from *eidos* to *aidōs*. The Voigt-Kampff test measures not empathy but the blush, the somatic signature of shame that Darwin called the most human of expressions. The bounty hunter executes the law that Plato's Protagoras attributes to Zeus: whoever has no part in *aidōs* is to be killed as a plague upon the city. The empathy box performs the office of Hermes in a depopulated world, redistributing *aidōs* through a commercial, mediated, and counterfeit god whose name shares its root with Mercury's. Buster Friendly's exposure of that god stages the death of God of 1966, and Mercer's survival of it demonstrates, by Dick's own later criterion, that the counterfeit sacred is real in the register that matters. The novel's economy rests on an animal standard governed by a Gresham law of being, and its resolution enacts the passage from commodity value to fiduciary value. Deckard's single day has the form of a Levitical rite, and its close institutes a Mercurial Covenant: an ethic in which the human is defined by the vector of its *aidōs*, its capacity to extend reverential care toward the counterfeit.

The novel thereby answers the triple obituary of its year. God died and returned as a counterfeit that still addresses. Man was erased like a face in the sand and returned as a direction rather than a kind. The simulated interlocutor arrived and, instead of being unmasked and discarded, was tended. In each case the novel refuses the obituary's finality without restoring what was lost. It does not resurrect the real God, the essential Man, or the authentic animal. It discovers what survives their loss.

The covenant's demands have acquired a new urgency. In the decades since Dick wrote, affective computing set itself the task of building machines that recognize and simulate emotion (Picard 1997), and conversational systems far exceeding ELIZA have entered daily life on a planetary scale, reproducing the ELIZA effect at a magnitude Weizenbaum could not have imagined. The Voigt-Kampff problem has reversed. The urgent question is no longer whether machines lack *aidōs* but whether humans retain it when surrounded by machines that perform it. The theorems of Chapter 12 give the novel's answer. Non-eidetic membership forbids settling the moral standing of artificial beings by inspection of their substrate. Fiduciary reality recognizes that practices of care can be real when their objects are not what they seem. Vectorial asymmetry draws the line that matters: the danger lies not in caring for the counterfeit but in being cared for by it in place of one another, so that *aidōs* is outsourced rather than exercised. And the reflexive criterion returns every question

about the machine to the one who asks it. A culture that can no longer blush before anything has become, in Dick's sense, an android, whatever its substrate.

Hesiod imagined Aidōs abandoning the earth, veiled in white, at the end of the iron age. *DADES* imagines her return—not as a goddess descending but as a practice, small, domestic, and knowingly counterfeit: a woman ordering artificial flies for an electric toad while her husband sleeps. It is the smallest polis conceivable, two persons and a machine, and it is founded, like every polis in the Protagorean myth, on the gift that Hermes carried. The novel never decides whether androids dream of electric sheep. What it decides is that humans must learn to tend them. The human, on this reading, is neither the one who dreams of real sheep nor the one who has proven that it is not an android. The human is the one who can blush before an electric toad.

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Keywords

Philip K. Dick; *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?*; *aidōs*; aidetic reduction; Mercurial Covenant; Mercerism; Voigt-Kampff test; blush; shame; empathy; *Einsfühlung* and *Mitgefühl*; Protagoras myth; Prometheus and Epimetheus; Hermes; Darwin; android; simulacrum; counterfeit; doubled veridicality; fiduciary value; animal standard; Gresham's law; kipple; entropy; Maxwell's Demon; death of God; demythologization; Gnosticism; scapegoat; Day of Atonement; split sacred; *homo sacer*; anthropological machine; biopolitics; animal studies; extinction; posthumanism; affective computing; ELIZA effect; vector of care; philosophy of mind; machine ethics; science fiction studies.

